HIGHER SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS
NATIONAL RESEARCH UNIVERSITY

THE GOVERNMENT OF RUSSIAN FEDERATION
STATE BUDGETARY HIGHER EDUCATION UNIT
NATIONAL RESEARCH UNIVERSITY
«HIGHER SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS»

FACULTY OF WORLD ECONOMY AND WORLD POLITICS
International Program 'International Relations and Global Studies'

Thesis Paper
On the topic :

«The KSA's Entry into BRICS: Impact of Joining the Organization on Saudi Arabia's Foreign Policy»

By the student
of the 4th year,
group 212
Artem Korsakov

Academic supervisor:
Andrei Zeltyn

NATIONAL RESEARCH UNIVERSITY

MOSCOW 2025

Table of Contents

1. Introduction.....3

1.1 Relevance..... 3

1.2 Literature Review..... 4

1.3 Research Gap.....11

1.4 Research Question & Hypothesis.....12

1.5 Methodology.....13

1.6 Structure..... 14

2. The Theoretical Basis. BRICS as an International Organization.....16

2.2 The Role and Place of International Organizations In the System of International Relations.....17

2.3 The History of Creation and Role of BRICS in the Company of Other International Organizations..... 20

2.4 The Processes and Stages of BRICS Expansion.....23

3. Prospects for Saudi Arabia's Cooperation Within the Framework of BRICS.....28

3.1 Reasons for the Desire and Intention of the KSA to Join BRICS..... 29

3.1.1 Expanding Trade Interactions..... 30

3.1.2 Diversification of Investment Partners and Attraction of New FDI.....32

3.1.3 De-dollarization and Alternative Financial Mechanisms..... 34

3.1.4 Balancing the Relations Between East and West. Geopolitical Considerations.....37

3.2 Reasons and Factors Preventing Full Integration and Full-Fledged Entry into BRICS..... 41

3.2.1 Strong Security Ties with the United States. Risk of Alienating Western Allies. 42

3.2.2 Conflict of Interest Between BRICS Members..... 46

3.2.3 Limited Integration into BRICS Financial Mechanisms. Dependence on Western Financial Institutions..... 49

3.2.4 The BRICS Energy Policy May Not Coincide with the Interests of Saudi Arabia..... 53

3.3 Conclusion On the Chapter.....57

4. Internal Political Factors and Foreign Policy Context As Driving Forces and Obstacles to Saudi Arabia's Entry Into BRICS.....61

4.1 The Internal Context: The Struggle of the Elites, Reforms and Economic Constraints. How Does This Affect Integration with BRICS..... 62

4.2 The Foreign Policy Factor Behind the Idea of Integration with BRICS.....69

4.3 Why Has Saudi Arabia Not Fully Joined BRICS Yet?.....76

4.4 Conclusion On the Chapter.....81

5. Conclusion..... 83

6. Reference List / Bibliography..... 88

1. Introduction

1.1 Relevance

It is fair to say that the landscape of international relations and global interactions is indeed volatile and subject to major changes. These changes are constant and the active dynamics can be traced on a daily basis. In recent years, the world has witnessed the growing role of international organizations and international institutions. In particular, BRICS block is an example. Over the past few years, the organization has expanded significantly and continues to build its policy. This is evidenced by the latest news from the 15th BRICS summit in August 2023 about the invitation of 6 more new countries to the organization, according to INDEPENDENT reports (2023). Saudi Arabia is one of those countries. Its potential entry into the BRICS group is an important event to analyze in the context of the transformation of the global order and the world order as a whole, since with the expansion of the organization, it will account for about 46% of the world's population, 28% of the global economy along with 25% of world trade, as well as 36% of global GDP, as stated by Holtzmann (2024). As one of the largest oil producers and the most important player in the Middle East, Saudi Arabia can become part of an association that positions itself as an alternative to Western economic and political institutions. An analysis of the prospects for Saudi Arabia's cooperation with BRICS and the possible impact of this process on the country's foreign policy is important for understanding the changing balance of power on the world stage. First of all, it is worth noting that the analysis of potential accession and prospects for developments in this area is extremely interesting from the point of view of studying international relations, since Saudi Arabia is one of the key actors in the Middle East that determine the policy and course of development from this region. Moreover, the very potential membership in an international organization may have consequences for the Kingdom as one of the main allies of the United States, whose opposite character BRICS seeks to develop. That is why such a study is extremely relevant and necessary in order to

find and identify possible fluctuations in the foreign policy of the chosen country after its potential participation in BRICS.

1.2 Literature Review

Further, as part of the research work in the chosen field, it is necessary to consider weighty and relevant scientific articles within the framework of a literary review.

At the very beginning of the literary review, it will be very appropriate to consider some theoretical works that focus more on the evolution and dynamics of the world order as a whole, rather than on some more specific cases and niche dynamics. Such articles can provide an important understanding of the general concept and current global trends, which is important in this study. This, in turn, will provide a certain starting point. For example, the work of Peters (2022) is "The emerging multipolar world order: A preliminary analysis. Educational Philosophy and Theory" offers a critical analysis of the changing dynamics of global power and dynamics in general. This work extensively traces the transition from the bipolar structure of the Cold War to the unipolar period after the end of the Cold War, dominated by the United States. However, recently the author has again noticed the transition to an increasingly complex multipolar system. Peters draws on the ideas of European Commission Vice President Josep Borrell, who describes the world's transition to different configurations of power - bipolarity from 1945 to 1989, unipolarity from 1989 to 2008, and what he calls "complex multipolarity" in the modern era. The author also notes the significant growing influence of BRICS, thereby emphasizing the redistribution of global economic influence in favour of the transatlantic powers. Conceptually, Peters relies on Wallerstein's world-systems theory, which considers global capitalism as an evolving system of core-peripheral relations. He argues that the current multipolar order represents a modification rather than a radical departure from this system, as power blocs such as BRICS seek to challenge the long-standing economic dominance of Western institutions.

Next is the work by Artner and Yin (2023), which is called "Towards a non-hegemonic world order – emancipation and the political agency of the Global South in a changing world order". It examines the role of the Global South in shaping a multipolar world. The authors argue that traditional theories of international relations have mainly focused on the dominant Powers, thereby ignoring the constructive role of the Global South, whose growing role now largely determines the world order. Moreover, the scientific work explores the processes of nation-building, economic cooperation and political resistance in these countries. Also, the main topic of the article is the dialectical relationship between the will to dominate and the will to resist. Artner and Yin examine this dynamic in the historical context of colonialism and decolonization. In addition, it is emphasized that the political movements of the Global South are inherently internationalist, since their struggle against Western imperialism and economic dependence has always been interconnected.

After the more theoretical articles, it is worth mentioning something more specific in terms of the chosen direction of this scientific research. The study by Malik, Kohar, and Tungkagi (2024) - "BRICS Expansion in the Middle East from a Political Economy Perspective", which contains a comprehensive analysis of the causes, dynamics, and consequences of BRICS expansion into the Middle East through the lens of political economy. In this work, using qualitative analysis methods, the authors describe and explore exactly how BRICS interacts with the Middle East region and how its initiatives and plans challenge the existing global dynamics of influence, dominated by Western institutions. The authors highlight and reveal BRICS initiatives to ensure the security of energy resources, as well as the expansion of their political and economic influence in the region to ensure more global ambitions to challenge the hegemony of the West. The article also highlights the desire of developing and emerging economies in the world to participate more fully, as well as to have the ability to have authority in decision-making processes. The authors consider the Middle Eastern countries as an impulse and an essential element in achieving common goals. However, it is

worth mentioning that this study does not focus specifically on Saudi Arabia and does not exclusively consider its motives and ambitions, which provides some opportunity to study and explore this element from the perspective chosen in the work.

Padraig, Carmody (2024) discusses a similar idea in their article. This work provides a convincing analysis of the consequences of BRICS expansion in the context of ongoing global geopolitical challenges and economic shifts. The expansion of the organization, including the admission of a number of countries, including Saudi Arabia, is considered and analyzed as an important event reflecting more serious challenges to the liberal international order and the increasing competition between major powers, in particular the West and China and Russia. However, the opposition to Western domination is viewed a little more broadly here, not only from the point of view of political economy. The opposition to Western hegemony is affected here through the creation of financial mechanisms such as the New Development Bank (NDB), as well as the desire for broader representation of the countries of the Global South in international institutions. The authors also criticize the internal problems of BRICS, noting that the inclusion of ideologically and politically diverse countries may weaken the group's ability to reach consensus and overall coherence for further development. Nevertheless, it is recognized that despite these differences, BRICS members share a common interest in revising the existing international order, which can stimulate future rounds of expansion and cooperation.

Barbary's (2024) work “The Impact of Saudi Arabia's Accession to BRICS Bloc on the Performance of Saudi Exports” examines how the Kingdom's accession to BRICS will affect the dynamics of its trade. The author's conclusions indicate a limited impact of the role of a country's membership in the organization on its economic component, which is confirmed, for example, by the fact that the KSA switched to a positive trade balance with the BRICS countries only in 2021-2022, but the study itself did not reveal a statistically significant relationship between the overall trade balance of Saudi Arabia and its trade with the BRICS

countries. Moreover, Barbary reviewed the overall export situation, which is certainly dominated by oil, and found that even the signing of the regional trade agreement (RTA) or preferential trade agreement (PTA) within BRICS would not lead to a significant increase in Saudi Arabia's exports due to low tariff barriers on oil and the low cost of non-oil exports. Moreover, the study also examines potential changes in imports, as imports from the BRICS countries are diverse and significant. But Saudi Arabia's high-income status and liberal import policy mean that BRICS membership is unlikely to dramatically change the country's import trends.

Moreover, Valamontes' (2024) analysis provides a comprehensive study of Saudi Arabia's strategic ambitions and plans in connection with its potential membership in BRICS. The article examines this aspect in the broader context of global economic shifts and geopolitical restructuring. The author emphasizes the relationship between economic diversification, energy market dynamics, and regional security issues. One of the key aspects considered in the paper is the balancing of the KSA between full-fledged accession to BRICS and the preservation of its traditional security partnerships with the United States. This balancing act is fully reflected in the Kingdom's hesitancy to fully integrate into the organization, especially in connection with the aggravation of regional security and the escalation of tensions between Israel and Iran. Valamontes says Saudi Arabia is still dependent on and needs U.S. security guarantees, especially amid infrastructural threats due to escalating tensions in the region. Moreover, the author considers the possibility of contributing to the diversification of the Kingdom's economy by joining BRICS. The analysis concludes that joining the KSA could accelerate changes in global trade practices and redefine economic alliances, especially in the Global South. However, the study highlights that the success of these initiatives will depend on Saudi Arabia's ability to navigate its complex geopolitical landscape and balance competing priorities between traditional allies and new partners.

Katz's (2024) article examines in more detail the expansion of BRICS by including new member countries, including potential Saudi Arabia. The author critically analyzes the geopolitical significance of such an expansion and examines the internal dynamics of the organization. Katz draws attention to the internal contradictions and existing tensions within BRICS, which can significantly affect the final outcome of their formation and expansion.: There are both opportunities for global multipolarity and significant challenges arising from internal disagreements. The author identifies two groups, which indicate the division between countries that fundamentally oppose Western influence, such as Russia, China and Iran (the first group), and those who maintain ties of cooperation with the West in the possible presence of some differences, including India, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (conditionally the second group). Such division undermines the idea of a single cohesive alliance, which is meant as a counterweight to Western hegemony. Moreover, the article focuses on various regional tensions, such as tensions between Iran and Saudi Arabia, and others that may hinder the bloc's ability to act in concert on global or regional issues.

Dr. Abdulaziz Sager (2024), by the way, demonstrates a much more focused study specifically on Saudi Arabia in his work, which offers an in-depth analysis of the Kingdom's changing role in the global order. Special attention is paid to its pragmatic foreign policy strategies and the study of multilateral partnerships, especially within the framework of BRICS. The study considers the Kingdom as an emerging middle power that is navigating a rapidly changing geopolitical landscape, using its economic might, regional influence, and global partnerships to actively participate in shaping a new world order. Sager considers joining the KSA from the point of view of energy security and strengthening global governance within the bloc, moreover, the Kingdom's very participation in BRICS would allow it to contribute to the de-dollarization program by facilitating trade in alternative currencies. The author also emphasizes that with the expansion of the bloc to the Middle East, it will be possible to test new models of inclusive multilateralism that

reflect the needs of the countries of the Global South in a more transparent and representative system of global governance.

Another comprehensive analysis of the expansion of BRICS membership, namely its consequences and opportunities in the article “BRICS Expansion: New Geographies and Spheres of Cooperation” Lissovolik studies (2024). Paying special attention to the economic, institutional and regional components. The author assesses how the inclusion of new members from the Global South (including Saudi Arabia) enhances the potential of BRICS in addressing the development challenges on the agenda, while emphasizing the need for structural and policy reforms necessary to optimize its effectiveness. The central theme of the scholar's research is the transformation of the BRICS bloc into a more inclusive platform, which is continuously linked to its expansion in January 2024, allowing the development of organizational institutions whose success directly depends on reforming their structures and organizational components to better meet the macroeconomic needs of the Global South. Moreover, Lissovolik examines the economic priorities of BRICS enlargement, in particular the potential for reducing trade and investment barriers within the Global South, which emphasizes the importance of trade liberalization and macroeconomic policy coordination for the development of the member states.

The following study already has a distinct approach, which looks more at the internal aspect from the point of view of the BRICS member countries and potential members. Abdeldayem and Kswat's (2024) provide a comprehensive analysis of how media reports in the BRICS member countries shape public opinion and political discourse related to the bloc's activities. A qualitative analysis method for studying news trends offers consideration of geopolitical interests, domestic politics, and global diplomacy. The key point of the study is the role of the media in shaping the image of BRICS as a geopolitical and economic entity. The authors emphasize and highlight the economic importance of media frames. It is noted that although economic trends and financial cooperation are important topics, analysis of changes in specific sectors or the economic consequences of

policy decisions is limited. Moreover, the article provides some conclusions that describe the role of the media in raising awareness and establishing a dialogue about the expansion of BRICS.

In an article by Holtzmann (2024), “BRICS enlightenment - a “non-event” or a stage victory against the West?" The recent expansion of BRICS is critically analyzed. The article examines its geopolitical consequences, internal contradictions, and the strategic initiatives it requires from Western powers. The main topic of the analysis in the framework of the study is the dual role of BRICS as a symbol of the empowerment of the Global South and a platform for geopolitical competition. The inclusion of new members such as Saudi Arabia and others is seen as a strategic step aimed at strengthening the economic and political influence of the bloc. From the point of view of Saudi Arabia, Holtzmann has a very limited view of the country's interests in integrating with the bloc, which, according to him, will help strengthen the KSA's geopolitical role both within the region and in the global geopolitical arena. Moreover, the Kingdom is looking for ways to diversify and improve its own economy. The article emphasizes that the BRICS countries are interested in strengthening economic cooperation to promote and protect sales and procurement markets within the bloc. In particular, there are efforts to create alternatives to Western-dominated financial systems. Holtzmann calls the expansion of BRICS a wake-up call for the West, urging it to turn its attention to the growing influence of the Global South.

Kamin and Langhammer (2024) consider the growing influence and gradual strengthening of BRICS bloc through its expansion to BRICS+ in their article. The expansion of the block is considered in terms of geo-economic potential, as well as global positioning. The authors contrast this with the dominance of the G7. Its superiority over the G7 countries in terms of the share of GDP measured by purchasing power parity (PPP), in addition to expanding its influence, which now covers a significant proportion of the world's population and a significant proportion of natural resources. This highlights its growing importance in changing global trade and economic dynamics. The inclusion of countries such as Saudi

Arabia is viewed from the perspective of significantly strengthening the bloc's strategic control over global energy markets. In addition, the article argues that the wealth of resources of the new members is consistent with the goal of BRICS to reduce dependence on financial systems dominated by the West and the dollar. The authors call the expansion a "wake-up call" for Western powers, urging them to resume diplomatic and economic cooperation with the BRICS countries.

Based on the scientific articles and literature reviewed in the study, it is worth noting that there is some similarity among them, which is reflected in the consideration of the invited or joined BRICS countries (of which Saudi Arabia is a part) together or in groups. There is a noticeable lack of concrete analysis solely from the position of the Kingdom, touching upon important aspects such as the KSA's foreign policy towards the countries of the region and relations with partner countries at the global level (such as the United States). This, in turn, leaves some field for scientific research.

1.3 Research Gap

Studying the prospects of Saudi Arabia's accession to BRICS and its impact on the Kingdom's foreign policy is a very relevant and insufficiently studied problem in the field of international relations. Despite the increased interest in the expansion of BRICS and the participation of new potential members such as Saudi Arabia in this block and active dynamics in there, there is a significant gap in the scientific literature in analyzing the long-term consequences and some forecasting for the foreign policy strategy specifically within the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia. Most of the existing scientific research on the chosen international organization focuses primarily on the founding countries and their role in world politics and economics, as well as on more global interactions and global fluctuations. Moreover, scientific articles often lack an in-depth analysis of the prospects for Saudi Arabia's cooperation with BRICS, as well as a direct impact on the Kingdom's foreign policy after its potential accession. In addition, the very novelty and freshness of such news once again confirms the lack of scientific research in

the chosen field due to the high degree of variability and the very nature of international relations, especially today.

Moreover, within the framework of this research, it is planned to consider the interactions between Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates as two rivals in the Middle East region. The UAE has already successfully joined BRICS, and the KSA is still in the process of considering an invitation to join the association. However, earlier, the Kingdom, like its neighbor, expressed a desire to join, so an invitation was sent to him. This situation is directly related to the competitiveness of Middle East politics between the two countries, and this study is also going to consider the factor of Abu Dhabi joining BRICS and Saudi Arabia's desire to join there, since Riyadh clearly does not want to lag behind its regional rival. Since there is a limited number of scientific studies on this aspect, this paper also seeks to close this gap in the scientific environment.

Finally, there is a very limited amount of research on the integration of BRICS into the Middle East context from the perspective of one of its largest players, Saudi Arabia. It is the Kingdom that plays a key role in this region, and its cooperation and participation in BRICS can have a significant impact on relations with actors both in the Middle East and in the global context. It is crucial to highlight and explore the implications for regional policy, including security, energy, and economic cooperation. and the relationship with other actors on the part of Saudi Arabia.

1.4 Research Question & Hypothesis

Before starting the paper, the following research question was posed: To what extent can Saudi Arabia’s accession to BRICS affect the course of its foreign policy and relations with key forces in the Middle East region?

After the question was posed, a hypothesis was formulated, the confirmation or refutation of which is to be found out in the results of the research: Saudi Arabia’s accession to BRICS will result in a measurable reorientation of its foreign policy, marked by a strategic diversification of alliances beyond the traditional

Western axis. This shift will manifest through increased economic and political cooperation with BRICS member states, a recalibration of regional influence in the Middle East, and a gradual reconfiguration of its security and financial dependencies—while balancing its existing partnerships, particularly with the United States.

1.5 Methodology

As a methodology, a qualitative thematic approach is best suited for this research to study the main topic – the impact of Saudi Arabia's accession to BRICS on the country's foreign policy. It was decided to use the theoretical traditions of realism and liberal institutionalism in the field of international relations as a methodological framework. Together, these two theories provide a dual approach to analyzing both strategic security considerations and the inheritance of national interests, as well as institutional cooperation to obtain benefits through international interactions. Realism, in turn, is used to interpret Saudi Arabia's strategic interests in balancing between its traditional alliances (especially with the United States) and emerging BRICS partnerships. On the other hand, liberal institutionalism underlies the analysis of the Kingdom's interest in multilateral cooperation, institutional diversification and economic integration with developing and growing economies, which is particularly present in BRICS.

One of the main methodological components of this scientific research is the case study. Saudi Arabia is considered as the main example, with comparative references to other new or recently joined BRICS members (such as Egypt, Iran and the UAE) to show the motives, problems and consequences of integration. This method allows you to delve deeply into the specific dynamics of the Kingdom's foreign policy in connection with its regional and global conditions, as well as to build causal relationships based on the analysis of specific events, linking them to the central theme – BRICS and Saudi Arabia's foreign policy.

Another important element of the methodology will be the analysis of documents and policies. This includes studying and analyzing official documents,

declarations of the BRICS summits (for example, Kazan-2024), government statements, communications from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, press releases from official institutions of states and bilateral agreements, and so on. This method will allow us to study these important resources and sources in order to identify formal expressions of intent, a framework for cooperation and strategic guidelines that, with a comprehensive approach, will form the necessary understanding to uncover the central theme.

Finally, there are extensive plans to use secondary source content analysis in the methodology. These sources include peer-reviewed scientific literature, policy documents, and reports from analytical centers. It can also include investigations conducted on Saudi Arabia by independent journalists and researchers. This approach to working with data will make it possible to systematically analyze sources to identify key topics, arguments, and conclusions related to the expansion of BRICS, as well as immediate trends both at the internal and external levels of the KSA (i.e., changes in its foreign policy).

This methodology aims to provide a comprehensive, multi-level understanding of how the Kingdom's international orientation and approach may change in the context of BRICS enlargement by including Riyadh.

1.6 Structure

Next, it is necessary to proceed with the description of the structure of this work. The task is to mark up the paper plan in such a way as to approach the analysis of the central topic of the work in as much detail as possible and try to find confirmation or refutation of the hypothesis. Globally, this research will be divided into three chapters. First, a theoretical chapter is planned in which the role of international organizations in the system of international relations will be considered, as well as the structure of BRICS and its growing role in global affairs. The history of the formation of BRICS and the stages of expansion of this informal association of the world's growing economies will also be considered. This chapter aims to lay and familiarize with the foundation of the BRICS bloc and lead to the

main part of the study, which is directly related to Saudi Arabia and the influence of the informal association on the Kingdom's foreign policy.

The next important step will be to consider the prospects for Saudi Arabia's cooperation within the framework of BRICS. Here, a more detailed analysis will be devoted to the likely reasons and motivators for Saudi Arabia to join the union, as well as direct attention to the obstacles that most likely hinder full integration. This chapter is important in terms of the impact of factors related to the country's integration into BRICS, as this entry has a direct impact on many foreign policy aspects for Saudi Arabia.

Finally, in the last chapter, domestic political factors and the foreign policy context will be described. They will be analyzed as driving forces and difficulties to Saudi Arabia's entry into BRICS. In this part, an important point will be to consider both levels – external and internal – in order to understand the driving and hindering forces in BRICS. At this stage, an analysis will be conducted from the point of view of the head of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman, with his motivations and personal goals, which are largely intertwined with the Kingdom's foreign policy course. An overview and analogy with the UAE's path to BRICS will be conducted, as well as an answer to the question of why the KSA has not joined the association yet. The chapter is an important and final step in understanding the impact of BRICS on Saudi Arabia's domestic policy, on its relations with key forces in the Middle East, as well as outside the region, with its traditional ally and partner, the United States.

And at the end of the paper, it is planned to summarize the comprehensive analysis done, as well as provide an answer to the research question posed. The hypothesis established at the beginning of the study will also be analyzed in terms of confirmation or refutation.

2. The Theoretical Basis. BRICS as an International Organization

First and foremost, it is worth noting quite an important thing: international organizations and their functioning in general. The concept of “international organization" (IO) has long been a deeply rooted and well-known concept in the framework of international relations and global affairs. In an increasingly multipolar and dynamic world which we can witness nowadays, regional and global organizations such as the United Nations (UN), the World Trade Organization (WTO), the European Union (EU), and BRICS play a crucial and integral role in shaping international norms and promoting economic, political, and security cooperation. That is why the study of IOs as a phenomenon remains an important basis for international relations and understanding of the modern world order as a whole. It is extremely important to consider the role of individual organizations, especially if their growing role and size can be traced, as is currently the case with the BRICS bloc. Its truly growing role and the number of participating member-states make this group of countries a significant actor in the international arena, including among other established international organizations. Konyshev & Sergunin (2022) define the BRICS group as a complex and interesting phenomenon that requires a multilateral approach to uncover the very essence of the state formation. They also emphasize the special essence of the block itself, trying to call it a new type of an international institution, which shows successful results in the form of its initiatives, however, according to the authors, it is too early to draw such unambiguous conclusions. However, what can be said for sure now is that within the framework of a study on a chosen topic, which is inextricably linked to BRICS, it is absolutely impossible to avoid discussing international organizations and their essence in general. This is indeed the case, as the BRICS bloc seeks to take root and strengthen itself as a priority and significant player in the international arena in order to enhance its global status, and, as Gavrilenko & Shenshin (2024) argues, the transition to a multipolar world is becoming more and more clearly discussed.

The purpose of this first chapter within the scientific research is to lay the theoretical foundations for understanding BRICS as an international organization, an international institution. This chapter is intended to examine the role of international organizations in the international system, because, as mentioned earlier, it is absolutely certain that international organizations are inextricably linked to the topic of the research, and their general analysis can provide the necessary trends and describe the current dynamics in international relations. Moreover, the chapter will also examine BRICS in the historical context of its creation and further growth, comparing its structure and essence with other global and regional institutions in order to answer whether the bloc is a full-fledged international organization. Finally, the chapter will study the expansion process and assess the mechanisms and consequences of the expansion of BRICS by attracting new, sometimes unexpected members.

2.2 The Role and Place of International Organizations In the System of International Relations

The growing role of international organizations cannot be overlooked. Even after the Second World War, the UN had already taken into account the multiple mistakes of its successor, the League of Nations, and had become very firmly integrated in the life of the world system and international relations as a whole. The UN still exists, which may indicate a new approach to conducting international relations, which is now being strengthened through the creation and development of both major players in the role of global international organizations and smaller players in the role of regional organizations. Barkin (2023) looks even further into history and evolution, tracing the development of international organizations since the 19th century, when early institutionalized frameworks such as the Concert of Europe and the International Telegraph Union were created. So, it can be stated that IOs is not a new concept, however this phenomena has been rapidly developed over time and in the modern reality it is one of the most important components of global affairs.

International organizations undoubtedly play a crucial role in structuring the global system and the world order as a whole, promoting cooperation, economic exchange, political stability and conflict resolution between states. Their very emergence and continued existence, along with their growing role, reflects the need for a complex and dynamic global system for institutionalized mechanisms to manage international affairs. These cases can include many things, such as trade, security, or economic development, which are attractive areas for the development of States.

IOs are also the subjects of multiple studies and discussions on their actual role, critical analysis, and prospects for their development. One of the scholars is Keohane (1984), who in his work on liberal institutionalism described the role of international organizations. He emphasised that they help reduce transaction costs, facilitate compliance, and promote interdependence between states. This, in turn, increases the likelihood of joint results even in an anarchic international system. Indeed, such an analysis is still relevant, because it is worth noting that in the modern world there is a dynamic of complex interaction between actors on the global stage. It may be a consequence of the ever-growing globalization, which inevitably leads to increased interdependence between countries, forcing them to engage in pragmatic interaction and cooperation. Nevertheless, views on international organizations vary significantly in scientific circles. Liberal institutionalists emphasize the role of international organizations in mitigating conflicts and promoting integration, while realist scholars such as Mearsheimer (1994) argue that international organizations serve simply as arenas for power politics, where States pursue national interests rather than collective well-being. Indeed, such an analysis should not be ruled out, because it seeks to deeply and comprehensively examine the true motives of actors in the international arena who seek to balance power and pursue national interests, which are primarily achieved through a zero-sum game. This theoretical discrepancy raises an extremely important question: are international organizations truly independent participants in global governance, or are they instruments of state power? This question is truly

fundamental, because an unambiguous and clear answer to it seems extremely difficult, perhaps even impossible. This discussion is not the central topic of this scientific study. However, with further consideration and analysis of the prospects for Saudi Arabia's cooperation within the framework of BRICS, it will be possible to pay attention to both aspects in the theory of international organizations in order to better understand and evaluate interests and initiatives along with their possible consequences.

Furthermore, an equally important aspect of this subchapter will be to evaluate and consider the evolution of international organizations, to consider their transition from functionalism to multilateralism, in order to consider in more detail the modern dynamics of international relations. Mentioning the functional approach, it is worth noting the work of Haas (1964), who argued that technical and economic cooperation between states promotes deeper integration. This eventually leads to political cooperation. His theory suggests some effect, which is manifested in the fact that once states cooperate in one area (for example, in trade and economic agreements), this often leads to further integration in other areas (for example, in security and political governance). Once again, we can recall one of the trends taking root through globalization – interdependence and interconnectedness. This dynamic can be traced quite clearly, since states benefit from such interactions, which can gradually develop into an institutional “shell” and become an IO (or at least an international institutional entity). Anghel and Jones (2024) write about the current dynamics of international organizations and according to the authors, international organizations that were once considered “exclusive clubs” are now increasingly forced to expand their membership due to external pressure and the changing international environment. Such an expansion certainly increases the level of inclusivity, but at the same time creates problems related to governance, decision-making, and conflicting national interests within such groups. This trend can generally be attributed to BRICS, which was originally an association of only five states – Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, but recently this “club has expanded to a large extent.” Moreover, in concluding on

the trends in the dynamics of international organizations in international relations, it is worth mentioning the idea of weakening the dominance of global institutions. Debre and Dijkstra (2023) consider this idea, arguing that the growth in the number of regional organizations marks a weakening of the dominance of global institutions. The scholars assess whether international organizations are in decline. They find that although the absolute number remains stable, their relative influence has decreased, especially in the context of growing regionalism and multipolarity, which highlights and once again demonstrates the changing dynamics of organizations in the system of international relations.

2.3 The History of Creation and Role of BRICS in the Company of Other International Organizations

The next important step will be to consider the formation of BRICS, the history of its creation, as well as its role among other international organizations. This step is extremely necessary in order to review and analyze the context of the block's existence and functioning.

The BRICS group initially consisted of five members: Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa. However, it has already become a significant organization on the world stage, reflecting the changing dynamics of international law enforcement agencies. The very concept of BRICS originates in a 2001 report by Goldman Sachs economist Jim O'Neill, who identified Brazil, Russia, India and China (BRIC) as fast-growing economies ready to play a key role in the global economy of the 21st century. It was this analytical group that laid the foundation for what later became the official intergovernmental organization, Neill (2002). According to the InfoBRICS resource (2025), it was the Russian side that initiated the creation of an informal group of BRIC states. At the suggestion of the President of the Russian Federation Vladimir Putin, the first informal meeting of the Foreign Ministers of the countries and also the Minister of Defense of India took place within the framework of the session of the United Nations General Assembly in September 2006 in New York.

And already in June 2009, the first official BRIC summit was held in Yekaterinburg, Russia, at which the leaders outlined a common vision for expanding cooperation, according to the official website of the Kremlin (2009). A joint statement was adopted, which included the goals of the BRIC, as well as highlighted the areas of cooperation and development prospects for the group's countries, according to InfoBRICS (2025). And already in December 2010, South Africa was invited to join the group, which led to the adoption of the BRICS acronym, which is still used today. The inclusion of the new member expanded the geographical representation of the group in Africa, as well as strengthened its position as a representative of the interests of the Global South.

Since its creation, BRICS has gradually expanded the scope of its cooperation to cover various sectors, including finance, agriculture, healthcare, science and technology, and cultural exchanges – most important sectors of almost all developed countries. Regular summits emphasize the initiative of the member-states to conduct and strengthen dialogue between them so that cooperation becomes more fruitful and multilateral (most recently one was held in Kazan, Russia in 2024). An important achievement was the creation in 2014 of the New Development Bank (NDB) with headquarters in Shanghai, according to the resource of the structure – NDB.int (2025). The purpose of this crucial institute for the bloc is to mobilize resources for infrastructure and sustainable development projects in BRICS and other emerging market economies. In addition, as reported by BCG (2024), the Conditional Reserves Mechanism (CRA) was established to provide financial support to member countries facing difficulties in the balance of payments. This, in turn, reflects collective efforts to strengthen financial stability regardless of Western-dominated institutions such as the IMF.

In recent years, the BRICS bloc has significantly expanded its membership to include other emerging market economies, reflecting the current dynamics of the development of international institutions in international relations. This expansion, as well as the potential expansion, is often referred to as "BRICS+". The inclusion

of new members and the expansion of the group will be discussed in one of the following subchapters.

In the context of the expansion and establishment of BRICS as a growing association, it can be considered as an attempt by developing countries to create an alternative platform for international cooperation. This largely reflects the role and functioning of the international system, which already includes many different organizations and associations. Cochrane & Zaidan (2024), for example, analyze the economic and geopolitical consequences of BRICS+. They note the continued and ongoing dominance of the G7 in global finance, but at the same time, the economies of the BRICS member countries are gaining influence in key resource sectors such as energy, commodities, and essential minerals. There are also many scientific papers and opinions from scholars, and the expansion and strengthening of positions from BRICS leads to a test of long-established unipolarity and the dominance of entrenched institutions through which large and influential powers like the United States project their initiatives and pursue their own national interests. According to Papa and Han (2025), it can be stated that the BRICS bloc is striving for soft balancing, using economic and financial institutions such as the New Development Bank (NDB) to counterbalance the financial dominance of the West. At the same time, it is argued that there is no direct challenge by military or coercive means, which indicates caution and pragmatism.

Finally, it is worth considering and answering whether BRICS is a full-fledged international organization and whether it can be called that on an equal basis with other well-established foundations. Indeed, it is quite common to see how the BRICS group of countries is called an “international organization.” Moreover, it is also common to find other descriptions of the association, such as “block”, “group”, “association". This is also why it is important to make such a digression and try to find an answer to this question. BRICS does not have an official charter or a legally binding treaty similar to traditional international organizations such as the United Nations (UN), for example. But in BRICS, institutional features and structural governance are quite clearly visible. It is fair to

conclude that BRICS does not fit the traditional definition of an international organization due to its lack of a legal charter, formal governance mechanisms, and binding obligations between members. But with all this, you cannot just call it a diplomatic forum, because it goes beyond its scope. Especially taking into account institutionalized financial structures (for example, NDB, CRA), regular summits and coordinated geopolitical positioning. Scholars often describe BRICS as a "soft institution" or an "informal international organization" that operates outside a strict legal framework, but still influences global governance, according to Konyshev and Sergunin (2022). Therefore, it should be concluded that BRICS is rather a hybrid institute or association that combines the features of international organizations, but it is not one hundred percent of it.

2.4 The Processes and Stages of BRICS Expansion

The next final step in the first chapter will be to review the stages and process of the expansion of the BRICS bloc as a whole. This step is extremely important for understanding and further analysis on the part of the bloc, since the motives and general initiatives for future expansion are clearly traced through the stages of an already completed expansion.

Firstly, it should be noted that since its founding in 2006, at that time, BRIC had evolved from a group of leading emerging economies to a significant player and association on the world stage. Initially, BRICS (at the time before 2010 – BRIC) consisted of four countries: Brazil, Russia, India and China. The first stage of the expansion of the bloc's member countries occurred in 2010, when South Africa joined the group, which expanded the geographical representation of the organization to the African continent. This expansion, in turn, brought with it an additional letter in the name of the organization – now BRIC has become BRICS. An official invitation to join the South African organization was received from China, according to InfoBRICS (2025). On December 24, 2010, South Africa officially became a member of the organization, after this decision was approved by all participating countries. Thus, according to EFSAS (2023), BRICS became

the first intercontinental group of developing countries to include a representative from Africa. This stage, through the accession of South Africa, marked only the beginning of further serious initiatives of the BRICS bloc. It was their indigenous members – Brazil, Russia, China, and South Africa – who carried out and implemented major initiatives (for example, the creation of the New Development Bank in 2015), as well as regular summits and meetings within the organization. The first step of the expansion contributed to strengthening the geopolitical influence of the bloc and strengthening its position as an alternative platform for global governance and unification.

Continuing the conversation about the expansion of the participating countries and the countries invited to join BRICS, it is most important to focus on the events and cycles of expansion in the last 3 years. Since they have become perhaps the largest stages at the moment (if we separate these expansion initiatives into one stage) of growth and increase in participants and partners. Invited members and countries that have applied for membership. It all started with the fifteenth BRICS summit in Johannesburg in August 2023, which became the second large-scale stage of expansion. South African President Cyril Ramaphosa announced that six new countries have received invitations to join the organization: Argentina, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, according to Cochrane & Zaidan (2024). This decision and decisive initiative demonstrates the transition to an active expansion of the BRICS group, aimed at strengthening the global influence of the bloc and further diversifying its members. However, not all countries accepted the invitation and joined the full member-states accordingly. Argentina renounced membership after the November 2023 elections, when President Javier Milei announced his intention not to join, according to the Buenos Aires Times (2023). And as stated by El Cronista (2023), on November 30, 2023, Argentine Foreign Minister Diana Mondino confirmed this step, and on December 29, the government sent an official letter to the BRICS leaders withdrawing from the accession process. In turn, the other invited countries, with the exception of Saudi Arabia, accepted the invitations and became

full members of BRICS on January 1, 2024. The increase in participating countries from five to nine was made possible by Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran and the United Arab Emirates. Speaking about the results of the major expansion of the bloc in 2024, it is worth saying that this stage of expansion can be called part of a long-term strategy to strengthen the position of the Global South, since the expansion of the BRICS bloc in 2024 took place precisely within the Global South, according to Anghel & Jones (2024).

As mentioned earlier, this scientific study itself is aimed at a very specific country – Saudi Arabia, which at that time (January 2024) postponed and left under consideration its accession to the BRICS bloc, as reported by Reuters (2024). At the time of writing this academic paper, late 2024 and early 2025, the Kingdom is still at the stage of considering its membership in the bloc. However, according to Arab News (2024), Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud himself, the Minister of Foreign Affairs of the KSA, joined the sixteenth BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia. He also expressed his willingness to cooperate and reaffirmed his country's commitment to further expand its partnership with the BRICS group. That is, at the time of the summit in Kazan (October 2024), Saudi Arabia is not officially a member state, but is actively acting as an invited country and partner-state, who also supports and confirms the desire for further cooperation.

The next initiative to expand its reach was on October 24, 2024, when BRICS took the next step in development, and according to CNA (2024), invited 13 states to participate in the partnership format: Algeria, Belarus, Bolivia, Cuba, Indonesia, Kazakhstan, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Turkey, Uganda, Uzbekistan and Vietnam. These countries have been granted the status of "partner states", which allows them to participate in BRICS initiatives and receive economic benefits from cooperation.

Finally, at the beginning of 2025, Indonesia joined a number of BRICS member-states, which officially became the tenth full member on January 6, 2025. It became the first Southeast Asian country to join the bloc, according to EFSAS (2025).

Summarizing the stages of the BRICS expansion, it should be said that, judging by the trend and active initiatives on the part of the bloc, this indicates the dynamic development of this international body. Since its establishment in 2006, it has gradually transformed from an informal economic club into an important geopolitical platform and international association. Historically, the expansion of BRICS has occurred in stages: from the first inclusion of South Africa in 2010, which consolidated the group as an intercontinental association, to a large-scale expansion in 2023-2025. New and more modern stages of expansion mark the inclusion of a number of new countries, as well as the introduction of a partnership format that further expands the processes of participation within the BRICS group. In general, the expansion of the BRICS confirms that the bloc is gradually turning from an informal economic association of four countries into a broad political and economic coalition capable of forming alternative global institutions.

Summing up, some conclusions from the first chapter of this study should be noted. As planned, within the framework of the chapter on the theoretical basis and understanding of BRICS as an international structure, an analysis of extremely important aspects was carried out in order to consider the BRICS bloc in the broader framework of global governance. In the current dynamics of the new world order, the BRICS group (and currently BRICS+ group) is being formed within the framework of a multipolar world order, creating and following one of the main directions – creating an alternative model to the existing ones, strengthening multipolarity. Of course, it is impossible to name the block of countries that is considered in this study in the traditional definition of an international organization because of its informal nature and consensus-based. But this association nevertheless plays an important role in shaping global governance and provides an alternative to Western-dominated institutions. Considering the theoretical basis of IOs as such, two main points of view were chosen for analysis: liberal institutionalism, formulated by Keohane (Keohane, 1984), emphasizes the role of institutions in reducing transaction costs, ensuring compliance and strengthening interdependence between states; and the opposite approach is a realistic one, where

scholars such as Mearsheimer (1994) argue that international organizations primarily serve as arenas for great power rivalry, rather than autonomous actors in global affairs. In this regard, BRICS is a unique case because it combines elements of both perspectives: it promotes cooperation and economic interdependence among its members, and serves as a platform for emerging powers challenging the traditional world order, according to Debre & Dijkstra (2023).

Additionally, the historical evolution and expansion stages of BRICS show that this bloc was conceived as an informal economic group, the purpose of which was to strengthen cooperation between the largest emerging economies at the time of its creation. However, with the time of growth and prosperity of the formation, it has significantly expanded its functionality and membership. Its very existence today challenges the dominance of Western-led institutions such as the IMF and the World Bank, as stated by da Costa & Sattler (2020), as it offers an alternative model of international economic cooperation, especially for the countries of the Global South. It is worth noting that BRICS occupies a unique position in the system of international organizations, even though it does not fully correspond to the concept of “international organization" as a whole. Its growing influence in economic and geopolitical affairs continues to strengthen the BRICS' position in the international arena, making the association increasingly attractive to the developing economies of the world. This, in turn, is evidenced by the expansion of BRICS over the past three years, when the group increased to as many as ten official member states and expanded its partnerships with a dozen countries.

It was extremely important to consider all this in the first chapter of this scientific research, even despite the narrower nature of the review by Saudi Arabia, which is still considering an application for full membership. Such an analysis is extremely important in order to consider what the bloc can actually become for the Kingdom and what prospects can be considered within the framework of their cooperation. The very nature of the BRICS group, its goals and further initiatives have a direct impact on the international relations of the KSA.

3. Prospects for Saudi Arabia's Cooperation Within the Framework of BRICS

As one of the most influential economies in the Middle East, Saudi Arabia is showing a growing interest in expanding cooperation with BRICS, a block that has transformed from a loose coalition of emerging market economies into a key forum for global multipolarity. And turning to a direct analysis of Saudi Arabia's prospects in the framework of cooperation with BRICS, it is worth starting with the rather obvious and most necessary things. Of course, we are talking about the reasons and drivers that push the Kingdom to work more closely and interact with the structures of the bloc, its member-states and partners. Within the framework of this chapter, the probable reasons that determine the desires and intentions of the KSA for further expansion of contact with BRICS and possible membership in the bloc will be considered and analyzed. It is worth noting that Saudi Arabia's interest in BRICS is driven by a variety of strategic, economic and geopolitical considerations, which, for example, is evident through initiatives such as economic diversification under the Vision 2030 program. This national plan aims to reduce dependence on oil revenues, attract foreign investment, and expand its role in global trade networks, including growth in the Middle East. It can also be noted that the deepening of cooperation within the bloc gives Saudi Arabia the opportunity to strengthen and diversify long-term energy partnerships, especially with BRICS states. At the same time, strengthen their trade relations and participate in alternative financial mechanisms such as the New Development Bank (NDB) and de-dollarization initiatives promoted by BRICS members. These are just some of the few potential reasons for the Kingdom's desire to expand its partnerships with the bloc or maybe even to fully join after some time.

However, in addition to a number of advantages and reasons for seeking rapprochement, there are a number of structural and geopolitical factors that make it difficult for Saudi Arabia to fully integrate into BRICS, as well as potential reasons why the Kingdom chooses a more balanced approach to interactions with

structures such as the BRICS bloc. First, we can note the continuing close relationship of the KSA with global financial and security structures led by the West. For example, the United States has been the main guarantor of Saudi Arabia's security for decades, providing military support, advanced defense technology, and strategic security cooperation. That is why joining BRICS in a more official capacity may be perceived as a departure from traditional Western alliances, which will cause concern in Washington and other Western partner countries about the long-term geopolitical orientation of Saudi Arabia. Perhaps this is a pretty good reason to choose a balanced approach. These and other significant obstacles, including the very nature of the Kingdom itself, will be analyzed in this chapter.

And it is worth noting that the chosen approach with an analysis of the beginnings and potential causes, desires and aspirations of the KSA from the point of view of both main theories of international relations - liberalism and realism - will allow us to fully consider various aspects from completely different angles. Moreover, this approach will make it possible to try to explain the reasons and aspirations of Riyadh for rapprochement with the BRICS bloc, but at the same time leaving its balanced approach in view of some reasons that hinder full integration.

3.1 Reasons for the Desire and Intention of the KSA to Join BRICS

First of all, within the framework of an extensive chapter on the analysis of prospects and obstacles to membership with its potential BRICS participation, it will be necessary to consider the most likely reasons for the state's desire to expand its presence and participation in the group. Riyadh considers participation in various international associations, alliances and organizations very carefully and with in-depth attention. The BRICS group, and in this case even the BRICS+ group, is no exception. That is why it is worth paying attention to the analysis of the desire of the KSA to expand its participation in the affairs of BRICS and to consider its full integration with the group in a positive way. Analyzing the prospects for the state within the group will allow for a better understanding of

motivation and true goals, as well as help to track exactly how Saudi Arabia can influence the state of international affairs both in the Middle East region and on the global stage. Of course, the focus is on the Kingdom's foreign policy and its aspirations in geopolitical affairs in the international and regional arenas.

3.1.1 Expanding Trade Interactions

Perhaps one of the key and motivating factors for the full integration of Saudi Arabia with the BRICS bloc is the potential for expanding trade relations with the countries of the group. And the establishment of more favourable conditions within the framework of the association can significantly stimulate trade relations and contribute to increasing the share of exports with fewer losses. As a bloc, BRICS represents a rapidly growing segment of the global economy. Moreover, it accounts for a significant part of international trade, investment flows and commodity exchanges. And that is why Saudi Arabia's cooperation with the BRICS countries opens the way to deepening trade ties with key economies such as China, India, Brazil and Russia, markets that are already among the Kingdom's most important trading partners. And the growth and strengthening of trade relations along with trade turnover, in turn, is an advantage for Saudi Arabia.

For example, at the BRICS+ 2024 summit in Kazan, the Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Kingdom Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, presenting his country's delegation at the summit, emphasized the growing relations between the KSA and the BRICS countries, according to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Saudi Arabia (2024). Moreover, according to the same source, the minister noted that in 2023, the Kingdom's trade and bilateral trade with the BRICS countries exceeded $196 billion, accounting for approximately 37% of Saudi Arabia's total foreign trade (“MOFA.GOV.SA,” 2024). Such indicators demonstrate the serious scale of existing interactions between Riyadh and the countries of the bloc. And in addition to this, it is worth noting the significant share that the Kingdom's trade turnover and trade in general the BRICS countries occupies, which in turn shows an important aspect of trade decisions on the part of the KSA. That is why it can be

argued that the already existing large-scale trade integration highlights how beneficial further deepening of economic ties through the membership mechanism can be.

Additionally, trade and economic relations between individual BRICS member countries and Saudi Arabia are actively developing at the bilateral level. For example, in 2024, South Africa and the KSA agreed to increase the volume of bilateral trade and investment, as reported by TV BRICS (2024). The importance of the growth of mutual trade relations and investment growth was noted. This step demonstrates the growing interest of the BRICS countries in developing comprehensive cooperation with Saudi Arabia, and vice versa, the KSA is also fully interested in strengthening its position in trade relations with BRICS and BRICS+ states.

Also, the BRICS trade prospects are clearly visible in the joint communique of the 14th BRICS Trade Ministers Meeting, which emphasizes a common commitment to promoting trade within the BRICS countries, according to the JOINT COMMUNIQUE OF THE 14TH BRICS TRADE MINISTERS MEETING (2024). This coaction is seen and planned by expanding the cross-border movement of goods, promoting electronic documentation, and countering unilateral protectionist measures that act as obstacles to trade flows. And of course, these collective goals are consistent with Saudi Arabia's ambitions to expand its exports and reduce transaction costs. And this can be done by simplifying trade procedures, which are discussed in the joint communique of the 2024 by the bloc. Of particular importance is the commitment of BRICS to a WTO-compliant, transparent and non-discriminatory trade policy, according to the Joint Communique (2024). This, in turn, further increases the predictability and attractiveness of the bloc for Saudi Arabia's trade interests. Furthermore, the block's strategic attractiveness can be traced through initiatives to expand cooperation in the field of joint production and distribution chains along with special economic zones. This provides for the localization of industrial production and the distribution of incentives among the group's members, which could provide

Saudi Arabia with the opportunity to integrate its industrial sectors into broader regional and global supply chains. Participation in such initiatives may allow Saudi firms and enterprises to gain access to new production partnerships and logistics routes, as well as benefit from simplified regulatory procedures.

Another extremely important aspect is highlighted in the 2024 joint communique, which says that the BRICS countries are planning and discussing a path to digitalization of trade practices, including the use of electronic bills of lading and digital payment systems. This, in turn, will reduce costs and improve access for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) throughout the bloc. Saudi Arabia is striving and gradually realizing the growth of digital infrastructure and is also interested in investing in e-commerce, in line with the broader goals of economic diversification within the framework of Vision 2030, which signals the potential benefits of participating in these innovations, which are actively promoted and discussed by the BRICS bloc.

Generally speaking, it can be noted that BRICS trading platform provides Saudi Arabia with many incentives to strengthen and expand its trade relations. If it falls within the institutional framework and system of cooperation of the bloc, the Kingdom can gain wider access to new markets, as well as strengthen the trade turnover of the already extensive integration with the BRICS countries. According to the Vision 2030 goals, the KSA seeks to diversify its trade and economy, which can be fully realized and improved through closer integration with the bloc. And of course, such trade initiatives seek to enhance Riyadh's role as a growing force and a key player in global trade.

3.1.2 Diversification of Investment Partners and Attraction of New FDI

Continuing to analyze the reasons for Saudi Arabia's deep integration with the BRICS bloc, the next important motivating point may be the diversification of investment partners, as well as attracting new investments from the BRICS member-states. And here it can be indisputably stated that such steps are key elements of the economic development strategy of many states, allowing them to

confidently develop, attract new partners, and strengthen their economic portfolio. This contributes to sustainable growth and reduced dependence on traditional sectors, which Saudi Arabia is actively engaged in as part of the Vision 2030 strategy, which focuses on the country's economic development and growth. Particular emphasis is placed on reducing the dependence of the state’s economy on the oil industry. That is why the diversification of investment partners is an important step for the Kingdom to secure and expand its portfolio, and attracting new investments from the actively developing countries of the BRICS bloc will bring the necessary economic push and momentum for the internal development of economic sectors in the KSA.

BRICS membership provides a unique platform to strengthen investment relationships with some of the fastest-growing economies in the Global South. Countries such as China, India and Brazil are actively expanding their presence in the international investment market. That is why BRICS is interested in creating favourable conditions for long-term investment flows. The importance of the block for investment diversification was highlighted at the Annual Investment Meeting 2024 (AIM) held in Abu Dhabi, according to the official resources of the AIM Congress and the news agency TV BRICS (2024). During the event, the president of the Global Fund, AIM Dawood Al Shezawi, noted the opportunities of the BRICS countries as new markets for Arab economies. He noted that Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Egypt, as one of the key partners of the BRICS bloc (Egypt and the United Arab Emirates are full-fledged members of the group), together account for 66% of the GDP of the Arab world. According to Dawood Al Shezawi, BRICS markets such as Brazil, Russia, China, and South Africa provide "new opportunities for growth and investment," according to TV BRICS (2024). For Saudi Arabia, this can indeed be noted as a potential advantage and a desire for further integration with the bloc, making it possible and more reliable to develop investment opportunities in emerging economies and attract FDI.

In addition, Saudi Arabia is already in the process of developing and expanding its investment geography, especially with the fundamental BRICS

members. Currently, the kingdom is the largest investor in the renewable energy sector of the Republic of South Africa (RSA), and, as reported by TV BRICS (2024), the total volume of Saudi investments in South Africa is estimated at 1.62 billion US dollars. This, in turn, indicates the desire of the KSA to strengthen economic ties with partners within the framework of cooperation with BRICS and diversify its investment portfolios. Such investments clearly contribute to the development of South Africa's energy infrastructure but at the same time open up new markets, economic and trade partnerships for Saudi companies and the country as a whole. Of course, such actions fall within the sphere of interests of the Kingdom and contribute to strengthening its position in the international arena.

It turns out that BRICS can really offer good and confident investment prospects for Saudi Arabia. These investment ties and advantages enhance the attractiveness of BRICS membership as a tool to enhance the Kingdom's regional and global economic integration and diversification, which it pursues as part of its extensive Vision 2030 plan. And this, in turn, will help Saudi Arabia to develop more confidently and take a leading position in the region by strengthening and diversifying its economy.

3.1.3 De-dollarization and Alternative Financial Mechanisms

An equally important aspect for the analysis is the issue of trends in de-dollarization on the part of BRICS. The US dollar has historically occupied a dominant position in the international financial system. And it is indisputably the main currency for most global transactions and reserves. For example, according to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) (2025) and as reported by Reuters (2025), in the last quarter of 2024, the dollar's share in global foreign exchange reserves was 57.8%. According to the latest survey by the Bank for International Settlements (BIS), the dollar accounted for about 88% of international transactions and trade in general. And of course, the influence and share of the dollar remain extremely significant. With great confidence, we can note the continued influence of this currency on global finance and the global economy. However, in recent

years, there has been a trend towards de-dollarization, a process of reducing dependence on the US dollar in international trade and finance. This process accelerated especially after geopolitical events such as the conflict in Ukraine in 2022, when about $300 billion of Russian reserves were frozen due to sanctions and other restrictions, as reported by Reuters (2022), which in particular prompted Russia to look for alternatives. And the asset situation itself has to some extent prompted countries to look for alternative financial mechanisms, including currency, to protect their economies from external (and even geopolitical) risks. In this context, it will be extremely important to consider the advantage that the BRICS group can provide to Saudi Arabia, which is striving for a high-quality and correct diversification of risks and the economic model as a whole.

The BRICS countries are actively exploring and discussing ways to reduce dependence on the dollar, considering the creation of new financial instruments and the use of national currencies in bilateral and multilateral trade. Such initiatives were discussed during the BRICS summit in Kazan in 2024. For example, as Russian Presidential Aide for Foreign Policy Yuri Ushakov noted in his interview with TASS (2024), he highlighted the importance of the group's economic and financial initiatives, as well as strengthening strategic partnerships in trade, investment, and technology. As a moment for creating conditions for sustainable economic growth, as well as expanding business ties and financial stability, the issue of creating a mechanism for conditional reserves and an independent payment system was raised, as Yuri Ushakov reports in an interview (2024). This, in turn, makes it clear about the priorities and objectives of BRICS as an association and the desire to enhance the role of the BRICS countries in the international monetary and financial system.

It is also important to evaluate such initiatives and their nature from the perspective of Saudi Arabia, as the subject of this research. The situation in the Middle East is very similar to the global trend of declining dollar dominance, which is observed in the region. This can be traced through specific statements and initiatives from the states of the region; for example, in January 2023, Saudi

Finance Minister Mohammed Al-Jadaan said that the kingdom was open to discussing trade in currencies other than the US dollar, according to Bloomberg (2023). This demonstrates the Kingdom's desire and commitment to diversify its currency risks, as well as its desire to strengthen economic ties with key partners (including among the BRICS member-states). China is one of these partners. In November 2023, Saudi Arabia signed a currency swap agreement with him in the amount of 50 billion yuan (about 7 billion US dollars), according to Bloomberg (2023). And of course, this is an indicator and an example of following the stated initiatives on the part of Saudi Arabia.

If we consider this from the point of view of realism, then we can say that such steps are aimed at ensuring economic security and reducing vulnerability to external financial and geopolitical pressures. BRICS, as one of the active actors among whose members there are adherents, is developing and discussing opportunities to create and strengthen alternative financial mechanisms. And if we look at the situation from the point of view of liberalism, the use of national currencies in trade contributes to strengthening cooperation with major economic partners (such as the BRICS+ states) and the development of multilateral relations. In this context, Saudi Arabia is demonstrating its readiness to make more active use of alternative financial mechanisms, which can be achieved, among other things, through in-depth partnership with BRICS.

Of course, in the current realities, it is too early to talk about the full-fledged creation of an alternative BRICS currency. Although there is a large number of arguments and opinions about this, for example, Dmitry Peskov, the press secretary of the President of the Russian Federation, reports on specific facts, according to RIA NOVOSTI (2025), that So far, the creation of a single currency of the group has not been discussed in the association. Nevertheless, BRICS single currency should be considered only as a separate instrument serving as an addition to the national currencies of the bloc countries. This currency, even if it is created, is more likely to be used for internal payments. Therefore, this sub-chapter mostly

focuses on discussing the group's initiatives regarding alternative financial mechanisms, which in turn are an attractive prospect for Saudi Arabia.

3.1.4 Balancing the Relations Between East and West. Geopolitical Considerations

Undoubtedly, an important aspect can be highlighted as the next step in considering the potential causes and interests of Saudi Arabia in the BRICS group - the strategy of balancing relations between the West and the East. The West here refers to the Kingdom's traditional ally and partner, the United States of America. Historically, it was the United States that actively pursued its interests in the Middle East, since the second half of the 20th century, to be more precise, and the KSA serves as a kind of “bridge” between the largest and strongest Western power and the region of the Middle East. The USA spends significant amounts of federal budget money annually to maintain and invest in the region, as evidenced by the SIPRI (2025) databases on military spending. However, Saudi Arabia has recently been actively diversifying its foreign policy and strategy. And one of such important steps and potential initiatives was to consider the possibility of joining the BRICS bloc and continuing deeper integration with it. This interstate association positions itself as an alternative to Western institutions and Western influence in general, which may be interesting for the Kingdom's balancing strategy. Undoubtedly, this process of integration is accompanied by internal discussions and external contradictions, which highlights the difficulty of choosing Riyadh between traditional allies and new partners. However, the main motives of Saudi Arabia are precisely related to the search for a balance in relations with East and West instead of the traditional emphasis on Western allies to a greater extent. The search for balance is also closely linked to geopolitical ambitions and considerations aimed at strengthening the country's global influence in the international arena and in the Middle East region.

As already mentioned, Saudi Arabia and the United States maintain a long-term strategic partnership. These interactions and relations are based on

common interests in ensuring the stability and security of the Middle East. According to the U.S. Department of State (2025), Saudi Arabia has been a key ally in the fight against terrorism, participating in the Global Coalition against ISIS (the organization is banned in Russia) since 2014. Moreover, the Kingdom actively uses the help of its ally through training by American experts in military and near-military affairs in order to actively participate in regional conflicts. Also, according to the U.S. Department of State (2025), contracts worth about $126.6 billion were signed by the United States of America within the framework of the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) system, and since 2017, agreements on the modernization of the KSA armed forces have accounted for $110 billion. All this testifies to serious and strong ties with the United States, as the largest and one of the main partners of Saudi Arabia from the West. This is reflected in ensuring security in the region, as well as the defence capability of the Kingdom itself.

But the strong and trusting relationship between the partners continued until a series of drone attacks on Saudi Arabia's oil infrastructure in 2019, as well as two incidents involving oil tankers in the Gulf of Oman. According to news sources such as the New York Times (2019), the attack on Aramco oil facilities began in September 2019, and oil tankers were attacked in May-June 2019. The Abqaiq–Khurais attack (also known as the attack on the KSA oil infrastructure) caused a temporary reduction in oil production in Saudi Arabia by almost 50%. Moreover, these events have significantly increased regional tensions and provoked a serious reaction from Riyadh. In turn, there was a reassessment of the KSA's relationship with the United States after these events, as Washington's reaction was perceived as insufficient. That is why Saudi Arabia began to actively seek alternative security mechanisms and differentiate its alliances, which included rapprochement with Russia and China. This, for example, began to be seen in later events, such as Saudi Arabia's solidarity with Russia during the crisis that began in 2022, when the kingdom led OPEC+'s decision to cut oil production, as reported by Reuters (2023). Relations between the United States and Saudi Arabia deteriorated significantly after that. Nevertheless, it can be stated that since then,

the Kingdom has been pursuing the goal of differentiating its alliances and finding a balance between East and West. This is also confirmed by the significant rapprochement between Saudi Arabia and China. December 2022 was an important step towards developing and strengthening relations with China. This year, a multilateral summit was held between the two countries when Xi Jinping visited the Kingdom, as reported by Al Jazeera (2022). At this meeting, the countries officially signed the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership agreement. This rapprochement once again demonstrates Saudi Arabia's tendency to diffuse risks and also demonstrates its commitment to growth as a geopolitical actor capable of skilfully finding a balance and not depending on one partner completely.

As for the advantages of the Kingdom's integration with BRICS in the framework of balancing between traditionally Western allies and the East, two global benefits can be stated: risk mitigation and the desire for geopolitical leadership.

From the point of view of risk differentiation, we can recall what was said earlier about cooperation with diametrically different countries and partners in order to avoid unilateral dependence on the United States. Also, initiatives such as integration with BRICS can help in terms of protection from an instrument of force such as sanctions. The BRICS group, as discussed earlier in this study, is actively discussing the transition to settlements in national currencies and is also considering reducing dependence on the dollar and, accordingly, risks that are directly related to Western financial constraints. Here it can be easily remembered about the freezing of 300 billion Russian assets by Western countries can largely be called an example and a “signal” to other states regarding such a possible outcome if national interests and strategies for geopolitical reasons negatively meet the dominant Western countries.

As for Saudi Arabia's geopolitical interests, it can be stated that joining BRICS would strengthen Riyadh's role as a regional leader and global player. It is fair to say this because the BRICS group positions itself as an engine of a multipolar order. As Russian President Vladimir Putin noted, BRICS advocates the

formation of a new architecture of the world order, which corresponds to the interests of Saudi Arabia, which seeks to avoid unilateral domination by the West. This was stated by Russian President Vladimir Putin in his press conference following the 16th BRICS summit, according to an official government resource. Kremlin.ru (2024), he also noted that the Kazan Declaration was adopted at the summit, which “reaffirms the commitment of all BRICS countries to building a more democratic, inclusive, and multipolar world order based on international law and the UN Charter.” In other words, the BRICS bloc can serve as a tool for Saudi Arabia to achieve its goals.

Continuing the analysis of geopolitical interests, Saudi Arabia's entry or further integration with BRICS would mean a shift from its previous orientation towards a traditional ally and partner, the United States, to the position of an independent regional power. It is likely that this could also serve as a reason to become the de facto leader of the Gulf Cooperation Council and the Arab world. BRICS can also contribute to this by being a multilateral platform for further cooperation and dialogue with the KSA's geopolitical rival, Iran. And although relations between the two countries improved in 2023, compared with their previous enmity, tension and the struggle for leadership in the region are still taking place. Therefore, BRICS can once again play a significant role in building and continuing a dialogue with Iran within the framework of diplomacy, rather than using hard power and proxy conflicts in the region.

Indeed, in conclusion, it should be mentioned that the reasons motivating Saudi Arabia to consider joining BRICS are weighty. The departure from the dense unilateral dependence on the United States testifies to the Kingdom's desire to differentiate its partner ties. Riyadh is striving to balance between the West and the East in order to grow in geopolitical terms. And integration with BRICS makes it more convenient and possible to pursue their interests by using the group's tools and commitment to similar goals to the KSA. Moreover, it is precisely the possibility of a group system of relations within the framework of BRICS that can become a field for Saudi Arabia to conclude bilateral and multilateral contacts, as

well as participate in group initiatives that may largely meet the interests of the Kingdom.

3.2 Reasons and Factors Preventing Full Integration and Full-Fledged Entry into BRICS

It can be safely said that Saudi Arabia's full-fledged entry into the BRICS structure is a decision that, in addition to its advantages, has some controversial issues for the country. Namely, the factors and reasons that hinder to full integration at the moment. Of course, there are clear advantages, which were discussed in the previous sub-chapter, however, the country may also face a set of structural, institutional and strategic constraints related to the consequences of joining or the factors that hinder this process. These obstacles reflect the deep dilemma of the Kingdom, which seeks to balance between maintaining traditional alliances with the West and exploring new opportunities within a multipolar world order. The purpose of this sub-chapter is to focus on analyzing the key factors slowing down and hindering the process of Saudi Arabia's full-fledged accession to BRICS. This is due to a number of important and weighty arguments. First, it can still be argued that strong ties in terms of security with the United States remain, including military-technical cooperation and joint operations, which in turn creates risks of strategic alienation for both Washington and other Western allies in the event of deeper integration with BRICS. Secondly, it is important to take into account the heterogeneity of interests within the bloc, where competing positions of its key members collide on issues such as energy, trade and important regional conflicts. This indicates the limited consensus of the group and possible difficulties in its further functioning. Thirdly, the presence of Saudi Arabia's financial dependence on Western institutions and financial mechanisms may also indicate difficulties in integrating with the BRICS bloc, which, in contrast to the dominance of Western institutions, seeks to reduce dollar dependence and separate economic interactions. In addition, it is also worth mentioning the limitations and dependence of the BRICS countries on Western financial mechanisms, which also complicates

and makes the process of separation complex and multifaceted. Fourth, it should not be forgotten about the energy policy of BRICS and its member countries (and, of course, its partners), which may differ significantly from the policy of Saudi Arabia, who is still dependent on oil revenues. The KSA has its own vision in this regard, therefore, some initiatives on the part of BRICS may run counter to the Kingdom's plan.

3.2.1 Strong Security Ties with the United States. Risk of Alienating Western Allies

Perhaps one of the key reasons why Saudi Arabia is still at the stage of considering its full-fledged participation in the BRICS bloc as a member, rather than a partner, is its strong connection with the United States. And of course, the first thing worth mentioning here is the direct dependence of foreign policy, especially in the field of ensuring its own security. The Kingdom, with all its desire, still has to put up with the fact that the country needs military support from the West. In the previous sub-chapter, we have already considered the desire to differentiate the Kingdom’s strategic ties and partnerships, as well as moving away from unilateral dependence on a traditional partner in the region, and this is indeed the case. However, one should take into account the fact that at the moment Saudi Arabia cannot simply withdraw from US military support instantly, without having serious damage or consequences for itself. Here we are talking about a strong and long-lasting security relationship with the United States, which stretches back to the 20th century, when America began to act as a guarantor of security in the Middle East region, and most of the Persian Gulf countries pegged their currencies to the US dollar. Close cooperation with the United States began in 1933, when the Kingdom began oil production, as indicated by documents on the official resource history.state.gov (2025), it was then that trade, commercial and other cooperation between countries was established through treaties. Since then, both countries have been in the process of maintaining basic cooperation, including in the field of security. And as already analyzed earlier in the sub-chapter about “Balancing the

Relations Between East and West. Geopolitical Considerations", we can safely say that Saudi Arabia acts as the largest foreign buyer of various military products from the United States. This, in turn, testifies to the crucial role of the United States in the Kingdom's military sphere. This is extremely important for understanding and moving on to analyzing the hindering reasons for the full integration of the KSA into BRICS, because an equally important aspect of this bloc is its own positioning of itself as an actor striving for multipolarity, as well as opposing the dominant position of the West. Therefore, Saudi Arabia's entry into BRICS may be regarded by Western allies as a step against them, which will directly affect their relations and agreements (including in the field of security on the part of the United States).

Turning to a more detailed analysis of these reasons, it is necessary to return to the historical events in which Saudi Arabia and the United States collaborated closely in the field of security. For example, we note again that the Kingdom is one of the main users and buyers of US military products, which helps Saudi Arabia defend its sovereignty, ensure territorial integrity, and pursue its geopolitical interests within the Middle East region (for example, through proxy conflicts). Moreover, according to the U.S. Department of State (2025), countries within the framework of the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) system from the United States of America have concluded contracts worth about 126.6 billion dollars, which again demonstrates the close cooperation and continued dependence of the KSA in the field of security from the United States. It is also worth mentioning the major agreement between the countries in 2017, which included the modernization of the KSA armed forces and the estimated military spending of 110 billion dollars, according to the U.S. Department of State (2025). Moreover, according to Forbes (2017), Trump agreed during his visit to the KSA that Saudi Arabia would allocate $20 billion to the Blackstone infrastructure fund, which would primarily invest in American infrastructure. Such actions and initiatives lead to the conclusion that the countries had extremely close cooperation with each other, and Saudi Arabia's dependence on military support grew and strengthened. Once again, it can be

stated that the KSA has historically considered cooperation with the United States as the cornerstone of its foreign policy, especially in the field of security. But at the same time, such a partnership creates significant obstacles to the kingdom's full-fledged entry into BRICS, which can have important and tangible consequences for the Kingdom.

Of course, such a strong bond weakened to some extent after the 2019 attacks on oil facilities in Saudi Arabia and the limited US response to this (this was discussed in more detail in Balancing the Relations Between East and West. Geopolitical Considerations”), which prompted Saudi Arabia to reconsider unilateral dependence and seek differentiation in the field of partnerships. This is evidenced by the rapprochement with China and solidarity with Russia in 2022 as part of the reduction in oil production. This was also accompanied by pressure from the United States on Saudi Arabia as part of the 2019 ban on the sale of precision-guided munitions to the KSA and the UAE amid a deteriorating human rights situation in these countries, as reported by Reuters (2019). However, even taking into account such actions and initiatives to move away from a strong dependence on a single partnership with the United States, Saudi Arabia still remains the main “bridge” to the Middle East for the West and remains dependent in the field of security. For example, the 2023 war in Gaza demonstrated the Kingdom's cautious approach to resolving the crisis, as it was more inclined to build a dialogue, including actively communicating with the United States and other European countries. There was even news that Saudi Arabia refused to fulfil a defence agreement with the United States due to the controversial situation around Israel, according to Reuters (2024), which in turn did not allow for a full-fledged military pact with a Western partner. But at the same time, the KSA preferred a more modest act on the US military pact, as well as a cooperation pact that allowed for the expansion of joint military exercises, according to the same source. This, in turn, indicates a more sovereign approach by the Kingdom (which was discussed as the country's new path in the previous sub-chapter), however, the fact that Riyadh is still ready and willing to receive military supplies and other

military advantages (such as joint exercises) from the United States demonstrates the very existing dependence and continuing strong bond in the field. their own safety. And this, in turn, is one of the most important reasons why the KSA is cautiously approaching the possibility of the country's full-fledged entry into BRICS. After all, such a step would serve as a serious signal to Washington.

The risk of alienation of Western partners from Saudi Arabia after joining BRICS may be increased by the fact that the group positions itself as a supporter of multipolarity and opposes the established hegemony of the West. This fact has already been confirmed in the framework of this study, when Russian President Vladimir Putin noted during the BRICS summit in Kazan that the bloc supports the formation of a new architecture of the world order, according to an official government resource – Kremlin.ru (2024). Moreover, in this regard, many non-Western countries may perceive BRICS as some kind of platform where a different and alternative agenda from the dominant West is broadcast. It can be argued that such countries want to be heard and contribute to international affairs on the world stage, forming new rules of the game that would be acceptable to themselves. Muktar Kedir, the Ethiopian Ambassador to South Africa, warns against this idea. According to TASS (2023), according to the Ambassador, Ethiopia's participation in BRICS is aimed at strengthening and establishing a more inclusive and equitable global system, which is achieved by deepening cooperation within the global South. He also noted the benefits of such initiatives in terms of strengthening the sovereignty of such states. These facts may indicate that there is some general commitment by the new member countries and partners of the BRICS group to redefine the status quo on the world stage. China and Russia, one of the main BRICS countries, are in fact the largest rivals of the United States and are experiencing some geopolitical tensions, and newly minted members of the association, such as Iran, complement this thesis of rivalry and confrontation with Western hegemony.

As for Saudi Arabia in this case, in fact, we can say that the state is not such an ardent and unequivocal opponent of Western hegemony. Of course, the

Kingdom pursues its own geopolitical interests, which can be achieved through close cooperation with BRICS. But at the same time, Riyadh is carefully and carefully building its foreign policy agenda, especially against the background of escalating geopolitical tensions between the United States, China and Russia. Once again, it can be said that there is an interest in finding a balanced approach that would not allow the KSA to rush to extremes and alienate Western allies from itself. As already discussed earlier, the steps towards rapprochement with China and Russia have largely caused concern in Washington, which is the reason why Saudi Arabia's full integration into BRICS is hindering.

In conclusion, Saudi Arabia's strong security ties with the United States and the risk of alienating Western allies are among the key factors holding back the Kingdom's full integration into BRICS. The existing dependence in terms of weapons does not allow us to fully take drastic steps. It is fair to say that Riyadh is striving for a cautious and balanced approach in order to maintain strategic relations with the West, while exploring opportunities to expand cooperation with other global players to achieve its own interests.

3.2.2 Conflict of Interest Between BRICS Members

The next extremely important aspect that may and probably is the reason for the obstacle on Saudi Arabia's path to full integration with BRICS is its heterogeneity. Heterogeneity in this case means that the group is heterogeneous, where there is a high probability of conflicts of interest. The BRICS member countries and its partners may clash in terms of geopolitical and economic interests. And this is not surprising, because each individual member of the association strives and pursues its own national interests in one way or another, including through participation in the bloc. Saudi Arabia is no exception. In order to achieve its own goals, the Kingdom may create barriers that appear through a complicated process of forming a coherent policy and agenda in the bloc. This may act as an obstacle for Saudi Arabia itself, since instability within BRICS or serious contradictions are more likely to make it difficult to develop own policies and

pursue own goals through the bloc. It can be fairly stated that Riyadh is not interested in being involved in other state's conflicts and contradictions, receiving negative effects and consequences from this primarily for itself, violating the plan for sustainable development.

Perhaps one of the most striking examples of the divergence of interests within BRICS is China and India. Both countries are the founders of unification and occupy crucial roles in shaping policy, strategy and agenda. Both countries are large developing economies with large populations, and both countries naturally pursue their own interests, which to some extent may overlap and contradict each other's interests. This is evidenced by the Sino-Indian conflict in the Himalayas, when border clashes in the Galwan Valley in 2020, as well as ongoing tensions in the Ladakh region, remained the cause and source of tension between the countries. India accused China of violating the status quo and escalating tensions, according to The Guardian (2020), and China in turn accused India of escalating tensions along the land borders. And despite the absence of direct military and major conflict between the countries, similar tensions between these BRICS members have been going on for some time, as exemplified by the meeting between Indian Defense Minister Rajnath Singh and Chinese State Councilor and Minister of National Defense General Li Shangfu, where "frank talks" were held, according to a press release from the Ministry of Defense of India (2023). Moreover, it is worth noting the discrepancies in interests within the framework of obtaining financial support from the NDB. India, for example, may insist on prioritizing projects in South Asia that would be beneficial and appropriate for its strategy, while China may be more interested in initiatives within the framework of the national Belt and Road Strategy that may diverge from India's interests. This indicates the ongoing nature of the contradictions between China and India. Such precedents and contradictions between BRICS members clearly undermine trust within the group and do not allow us to fully take important joint steps as a whole when there are similar disagreements within.

It will also be important to mention here the existing competition between BRICS members, as well as potential competition with possible members or partners of the group. This may directly affect individual countries, such as Saudi Arabia, in the case of this study, because regional rivalry is an obstacle to achieving geopolitical goals. Brazil and Venezuela are examples of competition for influence within the framework of BRICS. According to Folha de S.Paulo (2024), Brazil unofficially imposed its ban, that is, used its veto, on accepting Caracas as a partner country in BRICS. This can be viewed from the point of view of a conflict of interests between countries, especially regionally – both countries are located on the continent of South America and are forced to interact with each other in one way or another. Such an action by Brazil demonstrates the heterogeneity of the political environment in the bloc and its partners, whose interests may diverge or overlap in some areas. This is also confirmed by the geopolitical rivalry between India and China.

As for Saudi Arabia, it is worth remembering its historical tension in relations with Iran. Iran is a full-fledged member of BRICS. And yes, these two historical regional rivals restored their diplomatic relations in 2023, but it can still be argued that the parties still have a long way to go before the dialogue is fully normalized. Moreover, these two countries are still the largest actors in the Middle East region, where they both claim regional leadership, including on the geopolitical agenda. In the previous sub-chapter, it was noted that thanks to BRICS, Saudi Arabia will be able to use the group's tools and platform to continue dialogue with Iran within the framework of diplomacy. However, this does not negate the flip side of the coin – Tehran and Riyadh have overlapping interests, they are competitors for geopolitical leadership in the region and have some contradictions. As an example, Saudi Arabia's traditional ties with the West, and with the United States in particular, and Iran's adversarial relations with the same West. Such factors raise the question of how the KSA can navigate the complex dynamics within BRICS when it joins there. After all, the country needs to take into account the preservation of its strategic autonomy and regional leadership.

The conclusion in this case may be the fact that such contradictions, rivalries and the struggle of interests within the bloc make BRICS heterogeneous and create difficulties in its nature. In such an environment, it may not be easy for Saudi Arabia to pursue its interests and use the association to its advantage by 100%.

3.2.3 Limited Integration into BRICS Financial Mechanisms. Dependence on Western Financial Institutions

The limitations of integration into BRICS financial mechanisms and their own limitations at the moment can fully indicate a significant disadvantage and obstacle for Saudi Arabia to fully join the group. This point is extremely important for consideration and analysis from the point of view of the process that BRICS seeks to build in an inclusive manner from Western institutions, however, it currently faces a number of structural and institutional constraints. And these factors, in turn, slow down integration, limit inclusive financial transactions within the association and maintain dependence on Western institutions for their financial activities. And these difficulties are also compounded by the asymmetry of the economies of the participants and, as a result, their goals and approaches, as well as the continuing role of the dollar in the global economy. It is worth mentioning the latter in a little more detail. Indeed, the dollar still occupies a huge share in world reserves and is the currency of international trade (this was stated earlier in the previous sub-chapter, where the issue of de-dollarization was discussed). The same applies to Saudi Arabia, whose reserves are mostly in dollars, and the currency has long been pegged to the American one. It is certainly fair to talk about the intentions and aspirations of the BRICS bloc to reduce dependence on the dollar and more frequent settlements in local currencies, but this process is still at an early stage and requires a more thorough approach to take into account all the complications along the way. That is why it is worth analyzing the limited financial mechanisms of BRICS and dependence on Western financial institutions as a significant obstacle for Saudi Arabia to finally accept the invitation and fully join the association.

Starting with the limited financial transactions and mechanisms within the block, it is worth mentioning the New Development Bank, which was established back in 2014 and is essentially the center of the organization's financial activities. According to its establishment agreement (2014), it is stated that the operations of this financial institution can be carried out in the local currency of the country in which the operation is conducted.The Bank and the countries are actively considering such a possibility and are trying to practice it. This issue became particularly acute after the crisis in Ukraine, when Russian assets were frozen and a large number of economic sanctions were imposed. As for the bank, in 2023, the bank is still more dependent on the dollar, which is essentially a guarantee of its survival. This is also evidenced by the fact that local currency financing accounts for only 22% of the bank's portfolio, and according to the NDB (2023), the new president aims to increase this figure to 30% by 2026. This, in turn, may indicate that the main financial system and BRICS institutions still rely heavily on the US dollar, and initiatives to transition to their own system are still in their early stages, which to some extent may be an obstacle and narrow the planning horizon on the part of Saudi Arabia. This is also evidenced by the fact that although BRICS is taking steps to reduce dependence on the SWIFT system, such as the development of BRICS Pay and BRICS Bridge, some projects and initiatives are still in the testing phase and are unable to replace existing mechanisms. Of course, at the click of a finger, it will not be possible to immediately replace or offer a workable alternative that would still suit the partner countries and members of the bloc. Such mechanisms and initiatives are now positioned more as an addition to SWIFT, rather than its full alternative. It is fair to confirm this by saying that technological barriers also create some difficulties and complicate the process, for example, the introduction of blockchain and digital currencies requires time and coordination between countries with different levels of digitalization.

Saudi Arabia's limited integration into the BRICS financial mechanisms can also be traced to the institutional weakness of the association. This is reflected primarily in the fact that the group remains an informal association that does not

have a charter (such as in an international organization) or supranational bodies that could more effectively regulate the activities of members and partners. An important limitation here is the ability to make binding decisions. For Saudi Arabia, this can be both a positive point (from the point of view of its individual approach and the use of BRICS as a tool without serious obligations), and a negative aspect (as an example, the difficulty of forecasting or promoting any initiatives through institutional procedures). Moreover, institutional weakness is reflected in the absence of a single market, unlike the EU, for example. BRICS does not have a common customs union or other standards for regulating market relations, which is also more likely to be a repulsive factor for the KSA. This is fair to say, since the institutional weakness does not allow influencing the members of the association, for example, to facilitate the fulfilment of obligations to other actors.

And finally, a single currency is a rather important aspect from the point of view of the economy and the financial component of the group. To be more precise, its absence at the moment. The analysis of this aspect has already been partially touched upon in the previous sub-chapter, where its creation and promotion of initiatives for trading a single new currency were discussed. In the same sub-chapter, it should be said that the creation of a currency has not progressed at the moment and remains within the framework of initiatives and active discussions. Here it is worth mentioning a number of reasons why this process is difficult. First of all, this may be due to differences in macroeconomic policies and distrust of the dominance of the yuan or ruble within the framework of the association. China and Russia are rightly considered the leading BRICS economies, and their size and influence on the union are indisputable. However, this situation complicates the adoption and functioning of the single currency, if you think about it a little more deeply. Russia and China act as excellent examples of the opposite here - Russia's currency, the ruble, largely depends on oil exports, and China, in turn, is an active consumer of it. Its currency is more dependent on exports, which are driven by production volumes (which depend on energy

consumption). What will the BRICS currency be pegged to, if there is one? This is a big question, because the group includes many economies of the world, whose currencies depend on various factors and indicators. And how to balance such a single currency, if necessary, also remains a serious question, because different economies sometimes need diametrically different monetary policies. Such aspects can very strongly manifest themselves and influence in times of crisis. For example, we can cite a good analogy from history, when after the 2008 crisis, there were not enough printed euros for the PIGS countries (Portugal, Italy, Greece and Spain) in the European Union. Large economies, such as Germany and the Netherlands, had enough of these euros, but smaller and less economically developed countries did not. But printing even more currency would have led to serious inflation and worsened the situation with larger economies, which at the interim stage had enough euros to recover. This example also demonstrates that small European economies began to go into debt in order to recover from the crisis, and as a prime example, Greece's default. This analogy demonstrates very well and clearly how the diversity of countries and economies within an organization or association with a single currency can affect crisis situations and other situations related to the joint resolution of financial issues. BRICS currency should be considered as an addition to national currencies for internal settlements.

Another thing worth mentioning about BRICS currency is the strong dependence of economies and trade on the dollar. The countries of the group still rely on the dollar and it plays its key dominant role. US President Donald Trump has clearly made it clear to BRICS his opinion and attitude towards attempts to create a new single currency and replace the dollar in trade. His first statement in December 2024 in X (2024), indicates that the BRICS countries should expect 100% tariffs, as well as wait for sales to stop in the “wonderful U.S. Economy”. This is essentially a requirement and some kind of ultimatum, which should warn the BRICS states and it partners against attempts to replace the dollar and challenge its leading role. In January 2025, Trump again posted an identical post on his social network Truth (2025). This indicates the serious intentions of the

United States to fight and impose serious economic sanctions on BRICS, if necessary.

For Saudi Arabia, this should serve rather as a signal and a warning not to take drastic steps, including those related to full membership in BRICS. Such facts indicate the existing obstacles and the reasons why the Kingdom is probably still at the stage of careful consideration of its membership in the bloc. The imperfection of financial mechanisms and heavy dependence on Western economic institutions do not allow us to fully make independent decisions and not rely on the dollar, for example. In such a situation, it would be difficult for the KSA to plan a strategy and make forecasts within the framework of its own interests through the use of BRICS. Dollar hegemony and potential sanctions may slow down the process of full integration with the bloc or discourage it altogether. Although projects and initiatives within BRICS are showing progress, their implementation requires overcoming the structural barriers that are present in the organization. It is at these early stages of the BRICS' efforts to reduce dependence on Western financial institutions that Saudi Arabia can act as a small planning horizon for its further development, potentially being in BRICS. And of course, it is worth mentioning once again the Kingdom's strong dependence on the United States financially. This means that KSA's total investments in the US economy are huge, and in January 2025, MBS promised to invest 600 billion in the US economy over 4-6 years, according to Reuters (2025). In other words, KSA is seriously stuck with its money in the United States. And these investments need to be protected, for example, from possible freezes (as was the case with Russia and its assets in Europe). This seems to be almost the main obstacle that the KSA is unlikely to be able to overcome.

3.2.4 The BRICS Energy Policy May Not Coincide with the Interests of Saudi Arabia

And finally, the next important aspect that can largely determine the full–fledged participation of Saudi Arabia in BRICS is energy policy. To be more

precise, the problem is the divergence of energy policy and views in this area between the countries of the bloc and the Kingdom. It's no secret that Saudi Arabia is the largest oil exporter in the world. Its geo-political ambitions, as well as its overall policy strategy, rely heavily on oil and oil revenues. Of course, we can recall the Vision 2030 plan, which seeks to reduce the share of the Kingdom's income from energy resources, as well as build its own energy system (for example, the development of solar energy). However, the country is still very dependent on the monetization of oil reserves, and the transition and the desire to change this requires some time and serious efforts in this regard. As part of the reason that may stop Saudi Arabia from fully joining BRICS, it is worth discussing the possible strong divergence of views within the group on energy policy. This may be expressed in pressure on the Kingdom from other members or partners of the group to apply certain policies regarding oil production and other actions with it that the country probably would not like to do. Moreover, serious competition (for example, with Russia) within the association itself may also play out for the worse. And in general, oil dependence is likely to have a negative impact on the energy transition, which will make it difficult and force the KSA to choose a different path of development, while other major BRICS members will fight for the agenda and promote interesting initiatives (such as China or India). That is why this aspect can be stated as an obstacle, because Saudi Arabia may face fundamental contradictions between its energy strategy and the BRICS policy. And these disagreements, in turn, fully affect both economic priorities and long-term geopolitical goals.

First of all, it is worth focusing on the contradictions and some competition, which can become one of the decisive factors for the KSA. Of course, we are talking about Russia and Saudi Arabia (as a partner and potential BRICS member), which are competing for dominance in the oil market. Historically, there have been serious tensions and contradictions between the countries against the background of oil policy. This is evidenced by their price war in 2020, which was launched by Saudi Arabia. This confrontation resulted in the collapse of quotations and the

energy market as a whole. According to CNN (2020), this happened against the background of Russia's refusal to accept OPEC's proposal to help restore the oil market due to the coronavirus by reducing oil production. This contradiction almost immediately led to a 10% drop in oil prices, and Saudi Arabia, for its part, further aggravated the situation: the Kingdom lowered official selling prices for April by $ 6-8 in an attempt to regain market share and increase pressure on Russia. The oil price war began, which led to a quarterly drop in oil prices by 65%. There is no need to go particularly deep into this confrontation, it is essential for analysis in order to demonstrate that Russia can again take the other side and choose its policy regarding oil resources, since it is also very dependent on energy exports. It is important to note that Saudi Arabia wants to pursue a sovereign energy policy, and its presence in BRICS as a full-fledged member with a strong energy industry may overlap with the interests of other strong and influential members, such as Russia or, for example, China. The heterogeneity of the group in this case is expressed in the fact that some countries in it are highly dependent on the export of oil resources (such as Russia), while others depend on imports (China). This can, of course, be expressed in differences of opinion and views on oil policy, when lower prices and quotations may be beneficial to one side, but completely unprofitable to the other. Moreover, competition with Russia within the framework of BRICS may further be expressed for the export of energy resources to developing China, which may create friction and some contradictions.

In defence of the argument about the desire to pursue a sovereign policy in the field of energy and energy resources, it is worth quoting the statement in March 2023 by the Minister of Energy of Saudi Arabia, Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman. In his interview with Energy Intelligence (2023), he stated that if any country tries to impose a price ceiling on Saudi oil exports (for example, as it was done against Russia amid the Ukrainian crisis), Saudi Arabia will no longer trade with such a country. Such a statement makes clear the existing importance of the oil market and the country's oil dependence, which still exists. The KSA is ready to act decisively in the event of a threat to its sovereign development and the vital oil

component of its economy. This was the case in 2020 during the oil price war with Russia, which was provoked by Saudi Arabia. This approach makes it clear that being in BRICS requires much more attention from the Kingdom and the need to keep abreast of such situations. This, in turn, can act as an obstacle in terms of full integration.

Of course, there are no special bodies or instruments in BRICS to force other countries to comply with the agenda and follow one or another policy, including energy policy. However, the influence of large members of the United Nations can largely determine the course of the bloc, and the influence of such members may affect the possibility of promoting the energy policy they need, which may not coincide with the policies and aspirations of, for example, smaller and influential members – Saudi Arabia. For example, the KSA, as already noted, has historically had an economy based on oil exports, which provides a significant part of budget revenues. At the same time, BRICS is moving towards reducing dependence on hydrocarbons, especially under the influence of China and India (large, influential and fundamental members of the bloc). For example, President Xi Jinping, according to CNBC (2020), announced at the United Nations in 2020 his plans to achieve carbon neutrality by 2060 (to become “carbon neutral"), and to achieve “peak carbon” emission by 2030. And India, in turn, according to the country's Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (2025), is investing $4.3 billion in hydrogen technologies by 2030 and is generally very interested in their development. This again confirms the fact that there is competition for the agenda – each individual member will seek to use BRICS primarily for their own benefit, as a tool. Such “competitions” can be fairly regarded by Saudi Arabia as interfering with its own energy policy, which may delay the Kingdom in its role as a partner rather than a full-fledged member.

In summary, it can be stated that the energy interests of Saudi Arabia and BRICS remain partially incompatible and sometimes contradictory. Due to its continued dependence on oil resources, the Kingdom is forced to focus on them for the most part, since oil allows it to finance large-scale projects and set the vector of

development. For example, the BRICS group may be focused on diversifying and reducing the role of hydrocarbons under the influence of its large and fundamental members. The conflict of interests and the desire to set the agenda may complicate Saudi Arabia's adaptation of its strategy, which still relies heavily on oil revenues.

3.3 Conclusion On the Chapter

An analysis of the reasons and factors that make joining BRICS an attractive prospect for Saudi Arabia, as well as factors that push the country away from full integration, is extremely important for studying the understanding and ambitions of the KSA against the background of these processes. Such an analysis provides an understanding of the approach that the Kingdom chooses to conduct geopolitical affairs, foreign and domestic policy in general. And this is true because Saudi Arabia's very desire for cooperation and deepening relations with BRICS represents a difficult balance between geopolitical ambitions, economic challenges and institutional constraints. Understanding Riyadh's position and approach to considering its full-fledged participation in the association lies through an analysis of the likely reasons for joining, as well as consideration of factors that hinder full integration. The impact of this is undeniable, as it directly affects the foreign policy plans and strategies for the further development of the state as a whole. The analysis conducted in this second chapter demonstrates that Riyadh's decision depends on its ability to align long-term strategic goals with current risks.

Speaking about the conclusion for reasons that are attractive and generally act as potential advantages for Saudi Arabia through its full membership in BRICS, it is worth noting once again the prospects for strengthening and expanding trade relations. Multiple incentives underpin this initiative, as the country's tight integration into the institutional framework of the group will allow the Kingdom to gain access to new sales and trading markets in other developing economies (which are full-fledged BRICS members or act as partners). Strengthening trade, expanding trade turnover, and strengthening this component as a whole is in the national interests of Saudi Arabia, including in the Vision 2030 plan. The

advantages for the Kingdom are also hidden in other economic aspects, such as improved prospects for expanding investment partners and thereby diversifying its investment portfolio. Here, BRICS acts as a tool and platform for communication with the necessary and interested countries in order to establish a mutually beneficial dialogue between them and establish further cooperation. In this way, it will contribute to Saudi Arabia's steady development and leadership position in the region by strengthening and diversifying its economy. Another important economic and geopolitical aspect that is important to mention is de-dollarization and the gradual departure from the system of Western financial institutions. Participation in BRICS and its initiatives may allow Saudi Arabia to become part of a new inclusive system that the association is developing by creating and strengthening alternatives to dominant Western institutions, including financial ones. Such initiatives are primarily aimed at helping developing countries (which, in fact, also includes the CSA), as well as commitment to a new independent system. This is once again in the interests of Saudi Arabia, which welcomes economic differentiation and the search for a balance between the West and the East in all approaches. BRICS acts here as a tool that could contribute to the goals and interests of the Kingdom in this regard. And finally, as has already been concluded, there is a strategy of geopolitical balancing and differentiation of alliances and partnerships. This is a very attractive aspect for Saudi Arabia, which, in turn, is gradually moving away from its heavy unilateral dependence on the United States. The BRICS bloc is a serious and growing alternative to Western associations, which is gradually expanding and becoming a significant international unit that is gaining its role in the international arena, and this may be another opportunity for Saudi Arabia.

However, one should not forget about the most important obstacles and reasons preventing Riyadh from full integration at the moment. Such factors reflect the serious dilemma and contradictions of full-fledged entry into BRICS at the moment. Saudi Arabia understands the seriousness of such actions and statements, which would have serious consequences. Here, for example, it is worth

remembering the Kingdom's continued dependence on strong historical ties with the United States in the field of security. These strong ties largely “tie the hands” of the Saudi leadership, since the existing dependence does not allow it to fully move away from this. One can also add the risk of alienating the United States and other Western allies if Riyadh is quick to accept the invitation to join the union. Here it should be said about the calmness at the moment to stop fully relying on the help of the West and become independent from the point of view of ensuring their own security. The United States is the largest supplier of weapons to the KSA, and is also interested in buying Saudi oil, so a more balanced and careful approach should be taken so as not to lose the most important components of the advantages. The assertive nature of the BRICS group itself is also worth noting as a serious obstacle. The heterogeneity of the bloc translates into emerging or existing contradictions between countries (such as China and India), which in turn make the BRICS environment difficult to make decisions or plan (for example, on the part of Saudi Arabia). Moreover, following the self-interests of each individual country can make it difficult for the union to adopt a unified agenda or decisions, which is also inconvenient and contradicts the plans of the Kingdom, which is primarily interested in its national ambitions. An important limitation is also present from the point of view of the existing dependence on Western financial mechanisms (both on the part of Saudi Arabia and on the part of BRICS). It is also worth noting the imperfection of the group's internal financial institutions at the moment, which may make it difficult for the Kingdom to plan long-term and take advantage of such a system. The existing dollar hegemony both in the reserves of countries and in international trade (and for Saudi Arabia, also in oil trade and the purchase of Western weapons) makes the circumstances of de-dollarization more complicated and ornate. BRICS strives to develop its own initiatives and projects, but their implementation requires overcoming the structural barriers that are present in the organization. Finally, an equally important point as the most important obstacle for Saudi Arabia is the possible divergence in energy policy and the vision of the energy transition strategy as a whole. The interests of the Kingdom and the BRICS

countries can be called partially incompatible or contradictory, since the union, for example, has another major oil exporter, Russia, a strong and influential player in the international arena, and there are also large oil consumers, developing countries (like China), who see energy policy differently and are interested in low oil prices. oil. The leading economies and influential countries of the association can pursue their excellent energy policy, as well as promote it within the framework of the BRICS agenda and initiatives, which in turn may complicate the adaptation of their own strategy for Saudi Arabia with its strong reliance on oil revenues.

Saudi Arabia's cooperation with BRICS reflects its desire for multipolarity and differentiation, along with the choice of a balancing strategy. However, at the same time, cooperation with the association remains limited by the group's institutional weakness and geo-economic and geopolitical risks for the Kingdom. Riyadh is sensitive to its own security and stability for the sake of hypothetical benefits that BRICS can hardly guarantee right now in the moment. Nevertheless, in the long term, the group can become a convenient platform and tool for Saudi Arabia, which will pursue its own interests. This, in turn, will have a full impact on Riyadh's strategy in international relations, which will affect relations with other actors. That is why it was extremely important to analyze the causes and factors that are both advantages and act as dampening barriers.

4. Internal Political Factors and Foreign Policy Context As Driving Forces and Obstacles to Saudi Arabia's Entry Into BRICS

And at the end of this research work, within the framework of chapter 3, it is necessary to consider domestic level of analysis of the country and the internal political situation there. This will be done first of all, as it will give an understanding of the motivations of the Saudi leadership, namely, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, to enter the foreign policy level in order to strengthen his figure in the Kingdom. The analysis of the internal environment, the political situation, and how MBS came to power is one of the key ones in this study, since the KSA is an interesting example of a state where the internal political struggle plays a very significant role and determines the behavior of the country as a whole, both at the internal and external levels. Domestic political factors act as a driving force and encourage MBS to act at the foreign policy level as he acts nowadays, including initiatives towards BRICS. Moreover, this chapter will provide a direct analysis, including of foreign policy aspects that, together with internal drivers, bring the country closer to joining BRICS, which is just a part of the extensive initiatives of Mohammed bin Salman, who wants to strengthen his figure both within Saudi Arabia and on the global stage as a whole, including their allies, partners, or potential ties. Moreover, this chapter seeks to analyze and answer the question of why the Kingdom is still at the stage of considering its side within the framework of full-fledged membership in BRICS. In many ways, this is determined precisely by foreign policy forces and actors, but the cumulative analysis conducted in the third chapter of this study seeks to provide a comprehensive understanding of Saudi Arabia's motivations for joining BRICS from the figure of Mohammed bin Salman, the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, and also illustrates the main interrelated reasons why the country is slow to fully join.

4.1 The Internal Context: The Struggle of the Elites, Reforms and Economic Constraints. How Does This Affect Integration with BRICS

First of all, it will be an extremely important step to sort out the domestic political aspect of Saudi Arabia. Through an internal analysis, Mohammed bin Salman (MBS), the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, who actually leads the country and makes important political decisions, will have to be analyzed from the point of view of his desire to join BRICS structure, as well as to figure out why the country suddenly suspended its full-fledged entry into the association, as reported by the Saudi foreign commerce minister in Davos, according to Reuters (2024). The KSA is an absolute monarchy, so sometimes it can be said or thought that the state acts as a monolithic actor that makes political decisions both at the domestic level and in the foreign policy field. However, this is not entirely true, and even within a state like Saudi Arabia, there are internal contradictions that do not allow to fully act this way. They consist of different views on the implementation of drastic reforms and the reformist discourse of MBS as a whole. Additionally, relative to the Kingdom, one can also notice trends in power struggles, political confrontations between elites, and even members of the royal family. Moreover, the difficult economic situation in the country, namely with financing, in particular large projects (such as NEOM or initiatives within the Vision 2030), which largely determines the actions of the Saudi leadership and has a direct impact on taking serious steps in foreign policy, such as joining BRICS. It is worth starting an analysis through the prism of the internal situation that, in terms of its impact on foreign policy, including the Kingdom's integration with the BRICS bloc.

It would be logical to start with perhaps the key figure in Saudi Arabia at the moment – Mohammed bin Salman (MBS), the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia. It is worth noting that the path to his supremacy was not easy. He rose through the direct patronage of his father, King Salman. Initially, after assuming the throne in 2015, the king appointed Muhammad bin Nayef (MBN), the nephew of the old king, as his successor. As Ottaway (2021) notes in his work, such a step was also taken because King Salaman's three brothers were still alive, but they were too old

to be appointed crown princes. There are also opinions that these brothers simply did not participate in the political “games” for the throne. But today we have a different picture: the Crown Prince is MBS, not MBN. This is really not a mistake but rather the outcome of the approach of Mohammed bin Salman, who secured this place through political confrontations and intrigues. In 2017, the king changed the royal line of succession by appointing his son Crown Prince. Of course, such a step violated the right of seniority, because MBS is not the eldest in the family who could apply for this position, and in fact, as it was said initially, the king appointed MBN as the successor to the throne. All this happened precisely in favour of the current crown prince, as he managed to make the so-called "soft coup" (taken from the book Ottaway 2021), which allowed him to consolidate power in his own hands. One of the most effective and important steps was the so-called "anti-corruption" campaign, which was launched in November 2017. It resulted in the detention of more than 300 high-ranking figures, including princes, ministers, and businessmen. They were detained on charges of fighting corruption. As reported by Reuters (2017), detentions and house arrest took place at the luxury Ritz-Carlton Hotel in Riyadh. Among the detainees was one of the most famous billionaires in the Middle East, Prince Al Waleed bin Talal, who has significant international influence and capital, respectively. In fact, through this campaign, MBS consolidated his control and consolidated his hold on power. Through this “purge,” the prince managed to eliminate the opposition from among the elites who were his political opponents. Moreover, he managed to weaken the independent centres of financial power, and this also led to the undermining of intra-royal trust and solidarity. And of course, MBS took an extremely important step – he actually eliminated the former Crown Prince Muhammad bin Nayef (MBN), the nephew of King Salman and the former Interior Minister, from the “race for the throne.” It is worth noting that MBN was an extremely influential political figure and also had good support from the United States, especially in the fight against terrorism. According to former Saudi Arabian journalist Hana Al-Khamri (Al Jazeera, 2020), in 2017 MBN was removed from all posts and placed under house arrest, and later,

in March 2020, he was arrested on charges of "state conspiracy". It is also worth noting briefly such steps on the part of Mohammed bin Salman as the promotion of non-royal persons to high-ranking positions, which historically and traditionally were occupied by members of the royal family. For example, as Davidson notes, the most famous of them was Saud Al-Qahtani, who in December 2015 was appointed communications adviser with the rank of minister. The author notes that he actually headed the newly created Center for Research and Media Relations, which in turn was created to focus on shaping the agenda of local media and organizing interviews for foreign journalists with MBS. Or another example of how Turki Al-Sheikh, who, according to Arab News (2018), initially started his career in the Ministry of Internal Affairs, but then in 2015 was appointed adviser to the Royal Court at MBS, and then in 2017 by royal decree (where MBS was probably involved) was appointed royal adviser. After that he held the rank of minister and then became the head of the GSA (Global Strategic Alliance Co.). In this way, the prince gathered around him trusted people whom he could trust. Finally, it is interesting that the previously independent and influential post of Defense Minister was considered a significant force in the political game and arena within Saudi Arabia, but as Davidson notes in his chapter on MBS, the prince managed to quickly and effectively combine the elements of this completely autonomous position under his system, thereby expanding the network of his own patronage.

This analysis is important in terms of the consequences of such political actions by MBS. Such initiatives caused deep instability, which, combined with growing economic difficulties, created a hostile environment within the House of Saud for Mohammed bin Salman, and also contributed to the intensification of hostile sentiments towards him. The very decision to bypass the succession to the throne, which had remained traditional before him, as well as his actions to centralize power by appointing close people and purges, led to tension within the royal family. And this, in turn, jeopardized the internal consensus of the Kingdom's monarchy. Moreover, an important aspect here is the fact that the current Crown

Prince has undermined the existing rules for the distribution of power and influence, which eventually led him to a path unknown, competitive, not the most stable, and new, both for him and for the whole country. Such a power struggle has shaken the solid foundation that has served as a solid pillar that has kept the royal family in power for a long time. This is also why MBS, which is now effectively in charge of internal and external political decisions, faces the challenge of confirming and strengthening its legitimacy.

But just to gain the so-called "points" in favour of his own legitimacy, he needs to earn popularity and expand his influence. It is possible to receive these "points" both within the state (through reforms and gaining popularity among the population, which will be discussed later) and at the external level (participation in international initiatives; the foreign policy aspect will be discussed in more detail in the next sub-chapter). Against this background, the question of joining BRICS, for example, arises, since by doing so, MBS seeks to gain support among the growing economies of this informal association. This stands out especially characteristically in the context of deteriorating relations with the United States, a long-time ally and influential partner of Saudi Arabia. The deterioration of the internal environment among the political elite, which was once generated by the Crown Prince, serves as a shaky field for increasing his own legitimacy, which in turn is a reason to seek support at the external level, for example, in BRICS. Successful participation in external initiatives would probably strengthen the Crown Prince's figure in the eyes of his audience (due to his drastic internal reforms) – youth and women, and even more likely would increase support from people who were disappointed by unsuccessful early decisions. For the young population, for example, a step towards BRICS could be regarded as a clear sign of the independence of MBS from Washington, and to a certain extent would justify the funding cuts that MBS went to as a result of budget shortages. And BRICS can also become an initiative that can provoke a positive reaction from the clerical elite, who harbor strong anti-American sentiments due to the deployment of infidel armed forces in the holy land of the KSA during the "Desert Storm".

And as already mentioned, one of the ways is to try to create and maintain your own popularity – through internal reforms. And here it is worth saying that the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman, has chosen a very new and modern approach to internal affairs. According to the BBC (2017), MBS chose the path of "moderate, balanced" Saudi Islam, which is essentially a path of changing the strict form of Sunni Islam known as Wahhabism. Previously, the Kingdom had strict moral principles and norms, which were not disputed in any way. This was especially noticeable with regard to the restriction of the rights of women and religious minorities. MBS expressed his intention to reform such an order, making it more modern, minimizing the role of Saudi religious institutions, which were once considered critically important for the monarchy. For example, MBS allowed women to drive a car, which indicates the intentions and decisive actions of the prince as part of his reform course. However, this course of reform ran counter to the position of the traditional approach, such as the Wahhabi establishment and the clergy. As Ottaway (2021) noted, MBS was replacing this very establishment in order to create for himself a new main political base, which he was looking for in the eyes of Saudi youth and women waiting for the promised reforms. The so-called “Saudi populism” took place in this case, which Ottaway (2021) calls Saudi nationalism, led by MBS as a great reformer. But of course, there was resistance from Wahhabi clerics and high-ranking influential people, which only increased instability and division, which in turn prevented the gaining of “points” for the legitimacy of Mohammed bin Salman.

In this aspect, we can give a very reasonable and applicable idea from the point of view of the clash of cultures, which is becoming more and more obvious and indisputable in Saudi Arabia. This refers to the thoughts of political scientist Samuel Huntington (1968), who spoke about the high risk of failure for modernizing monarchs (such as MBS in our case). This risk lies in the emerging gap and balancing of such a monarch between the forces of the old order (which oppose reforms) and the forces created by the reforms. Samuel Huntington believes that in this case, the monarch may even be overthrown by the forces of the

new order and also calls this phenomenon “the king's dilemma.” Wahhabi forces are opposed to such drastic reforms in the case of Saudi Arabia, and their very importance is marked by the long history of being an important and mainstay of the kingdom of Al-Saud, which is largely undermined by MBS.

It turns out that due to the unstable environment that has developed as a result of political actions and other initiatives such as coordinated reforms, Mohammed bin Salman has created a difficult situation for himself as a possible future ruler. One of the main questions for him remains whether he will retain power and ascend to the throne after the death of his father, who is currently the King of Saudi Arabia. As a political figure, MBS is a special example among Middle Eastern reformers because he came to power at an early age and also chose a very controversial path of reform to strengthen his legitimacy and power in the future. The Crown Prince's behavior is often described as impulsive, authoritarian, and driven by personal ambitions, which is reflected in his political decisions, economic initiatives, and management style. That is why MBS chooses to rely on external relations and this level as whole, including BRICS, as a search for support.

The economic and financial aspects speak even more vividly about the existing problematic environment under Mohammed bin Salman. In 2016, the Vision 2030 plan was adopted, which provides for the differentiation of the Kingdom's economy, important reforms, as well as the implementation of major projects (such as NEOM). Not the most competent management of the budget and finances on the part of the government of Saudi Arabia, namely MBS, entails an increase in dependence on external investments, as well as an even stronger strengthening of dependence on oil revenues (the share of which, according to the plan, should be significantly reduced by 2030). Davidson, in his chapter on MBS, notes that back in April 2016, the MBS team, responding to the alleged crisis, admitted to the international media that the country's expenses during the reign of King Abdullah were simply enormous and approximately 80-100 billion dollars were spent inefficiently annually. With such a background, Mohammed bin Salman

came to power, and with him, grandiose projects that required huge funding from the budget, which had yet to be stabilized. In their work “Blood and Oil: Mohammed bin Salman's Ruthless Quest for Global Power,” the authors Hope & Scheck (2020) highlight the Kingdom's existing heavy dependence on foreign investment and global partnerships (which, by the way, may become BRICS in the future) and also note that the Vision 2030 program risks being overly ambitious and underfunded. In many ways, foreign partnerships and connections have been shaken after the murder of journalist Jamal Khashoggi in 2018. The US report (Al Jazeera, 2021) describes the assassination operation in many ways, which in turn greatly damaged the reputation of MBS at the international level. Meanwhile, selected mega projects for the country totaled about $2 trillion to free Saudi Arabia from dependence on oil, according to Bloomberg (2016). However, under the leadership of Mohammed bin Salman, not the most successful initiatives have been noted, which have greatly increased the financial difficulties of the Kingdom that are currently being observed. Such initiatives include the costly war in Yemen, which is dragging on and still remains relevant, but in turn is not an example of a good and competent policy on the part of MBS and does not go into his “bank of points." It is also possible to note the ineffectual blockade of Qatar, which, in fact, ended in nothing useful for Saudi Arabia. Reforms are hampered by a lack of budget, and their scale forces the country to take loans and rely even more on external financing. For example, according to the Middle East Monitor (2020), Saudi Arabia has taken out a loan to finance part of its mega-project NEOM, a futuristic city-state estimated to cost $500 billion. The NEOM project is currently experiencing some difficulties, again due to its financial component. According to a report by The Wall Street Journal (2025), the project is turning into a financial disaster. As noted in the report, delays and cost overruns, which, by the way, have already cost about $50 billion, the country may well face another 55 years of construction. It is also noted that the projected cost of the project will be 8.8 trillion dollars. This, in turn, is an example of not the most correct and predictable investments on the part of the Saudi government, which exacerbate contradictions

among the elites and the population. And to confirm the difficulty with finances, we can cite the events of early 2025, which Saudi Arabia began with a $12 billion bond issue and a PIF loan, according to Bloomberg (2025), to cover the prince's projects and initiatives. It cannot be said that all this together benefits the popularity and strengthening of his position (including in the future) for MBS.

Collectively, the internal aspect includes MBS coming to power through a serious political struggle that created an unstable environment and attitude towards Mohammed bin Salman on the part of the elite; drastic reforms of public life and opposition to traditional foundations in order to gain a new base of support; as well as not the most successful mega-projects that require huge finances resulting decline in the country's budget and economy, which has serious consequences. These consequences create difficulties for MBS to promote his position and political figure as the future King. That is why he has to seek support and gain “points” in favor of himself at the external level, by depending on foreign policy actors (for example, financially), as well as by participating in BRICS-type initiatives that could play in his favor. It is safe to say that the internal environment, which MBS himself “tore apart” and made unstable, pushes him to justify and strengthen his legitimacy through BRICS for instance, an association in which the major growing economies of the world – like China, Russia, India, and other members participate. For example, taking advantage of China's great financial opportunities probably would be easier through the collective structure of BRICS and participation in group initiatives involving Beijing. The influence of such foreign policy partners as large economies within the framework of the association can play an important role, and the success of the initiative with BRICS for Saudi Arabia will help MBS by being added to his “portfolio".

4.2 The Foreign Policy Factor Behind the Idea of Integration with BRICS

The foreign policy factor, or the external level, acts as one of the most decisive and significant motivators for Mohammed bin Salman to seriously consider integration into BRICS. The previous sub-chapter analyzed the internal

aspect of the Kingdom, the environment and circumstances that did not work out in the best way for the government, namely MBS in particular, in order to confidently strengthen its own position among the elite through internal reforms. That is why MBS is forced to seek support and strengthen his political figure at this very external level. Of course, there are many advantages that the country could gain from joining BRICS and further cooperation with it. Similar economic (mainly) and geopolitical advantages have already been discussed in the second chapter. In this section, it is planned to consider the foreign policy factor that determines the idea of Saudi Arabia joining the informal association of developing countries. A more detailed analysis will be carried out through the personality of Mohammed bin Salman, namely his desire to strengthen his figure on the external level (and by doing that on internal level also). Here it is worth noting some important drivers that are probably pushing MBS towards integration with BRICS. First of all, this is an internal factor, which was analyzed earlier, forcing us to act at the foreign policy level. At this level, it is worth noting such a key figure as Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan (aka MBZ), who has been President of the United Arab Emirates and Emir of Abu Dhabi since 2022. This figure is important for analysis at the foreign policy level, as she is a role model for Mohammed bin Salman, as well as to some extent an opponent and rival in terms of regional dominance (the KSA and the UAE are neighbors, as well as the large economies of the Middle East). And as is already known, the United Arab Emirates fully joined BRICS, and more importantly, Saudi Arabia expressed a desire to join the group at about the same time as its neighbor, after which invitations were sent to them. This aspect is to be considered as one of the fundamental drivers of MBS to keep up with MBZ. And of course, in view of its deterioration and some cooling in relations between the KSA and the United States (this was discussed in more detail in Chapter 2), the Kingdom, led by the Crown Prince, seeks to create some kind of “pressure lever” and counterweight in foreign policy partnerships and alliances. Washington is definitely meeting initiatives to integrate with BRICS negatively, because as it is known and as stated in the article on Maal (2023), for the United States, Saudi

Arabia is a key partner and ally in the region, as well as the main buyer of American weapons and one of the main investment centers (about $ 800 billion). Losing touch or allowing rapprochement with their geopolitical rivals (China and Russia within the framework of BRICS) is definitely not beneficial or interesting for Washington, so this “pressure lever” from Saudi Arabia may work in favor of Riyadh, as well as strengthen MBS as a strong geopolitical strategist and figure in general. Such initiatives can generally benefit Mohammed bin Salman, because they will allow him to gain so-called “points” in his favor, in order to consolidate himself in the future as the most suitable successor to the royal throne.

First of all, it is worth starting a foreign policy analysis precisely from the point of view of the orientation of policy on the part of MBS to MBZ. The connection between them is really extremely important for understanding the current situation, as well as analyzing the references and reasons why the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia nevertheless took important and great steps towards integration with BRICS. This connection is evident in some kind of existing mentoring, where MBZ acts as a role model for his younger colleague from the neighboring Kingdom. Davidson, for example, notes that the Crown Prince (now the president) of the UAE probably contributed to the rise of MBS, and also notes the likelihood that MBZ acted as a consultant and directly provided its assistance. This is very important because in the Middle East there is a so-called high-context (a term coined by Edward T. Hall in 1959) characteristic of culture. It explains the importance of building personal relationships and their key importance in such cultures. Mutual relations and strong ties have a very strong impact in a region like the Middle East, especially among states with a monarchical system (the KSA). That is why it is extremely important to note this linkage between MBS and MBZ, which largely predetermined the foreign policy decisions of the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia (including the intention to join BRICS). It is also worth noting that Mohammed bin Zayed himself confessed to an American diplomat in 2005 that he was very concerned about the possible collapse of the House of Saud (regarding terrorist threats) and therefore there was a desire to help them, according to the US

Department of State (2005). However, the rhetoric is not as direct and unambiguous as it might seem at first glance. For example, according to the US Department of State (2009), the UAE, in its statements about close ties with the Kingdom, privately considers Riyadh as the second largest security threat after Iran for itself, which is historically based on rivalry and hostility between states. This, in turn, suggests that despite the close ties between the political representatives of these countries, over the past decade there has still been regional rivalry between the countries, sometimes some hidden confrontation for leadership.

Revealing in more detail the aspect of the existing imitation on the part of MBS towards his colleague MBZ, it is worth noting that after the first political advances of the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, as stated by Davidson, many assumed that the so-called “symbiotic mentor-mentee relationship” had developed between these figures, which were based on common interests. The New York Times (2020), for example, noted a similar connection between the two men, saying that "MBS ... in many ways is MBZ's protégé," and The Guardians (2018) wrote that Mohammed bin Zayed acted as a mentor to the young Mohammed bin Salman on his way up the political ladder. This largely explains the established bond between them, and also formed a kind of role model for the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, who was guided by his senior colleague in introducing international affairs and participating in joint initiatives. Davidson also argues for international relations, namely, very specific actions on the part of MBS, which conducted joint actions and even acted under the leadership of MBZ, such as in 2015, after assuming the post of Defense Minister Mohammed bin Salman, a joint operation with the UAE against the Houthi forces in Yemen began. Of course, both countries (the KSA and the UAE) pursued common goals in the war in Yemen, but the influence of a senior colleague from Abu Dhabi largely predetermined the discourse and actions on the part of Riyadh. It is also noted that the subsequent statements towards Iran from Saudi Arabia followed this discourse and largely coincided with the statements of MBZ. Moving further up the ladder to the title of Crown Prince, Davidson notes that MBS most likely enjoyed the support of the

UAE, as evidenced by the fact that Abu Dhabi secured the necessary support from the Kingdom within the framework of the anti-terrorism coalition (including Egypt and Bahrain). The author notes that this was probably part of the deal, as it happened only a few weeks before MBS officially assumed the role of Crown Prince of KSA. Perhaps it is thanks to MBZ's help and influence that Saudi Arabia's crown Prince is now exactly the one we know. And, of course, this cannot but affect the influence of the figure of Mohammed bin Zayed on MBS in his further foreign policy affairs, including his intention to join BRICS. Moreover, it is vital to say that, of course, Mohammed bin Salman's track record in foreign policy leaves much to be desired. As previously described, the protracted war in Yemen and its cost do not play in favour of the politician, and is also essentially a failure. The failure also lies in the fact that through not the most thoughtful foreign policy initiatives, Saudi Arabia lost a close ally in this war – the United Arab Emirates. Moreover, the air, land and sea boycott of Qatar, which was not the most successful in terms of effectiveness, did not lead to anything (Qatar was greatly helped by the KSA's long–time opponent, Iran, a strong and influential player in the Middle East arena), although not a little effort was spent on this confrontation.

From this point of view, it can be concluded that the initiatives that were quite successful, as well as the promotion itself, were carried out thanks to the "patronage" of MBZ. And even despite the deterioration of relations between the KSA and the UAE, it would be fair to say that Mohammed bin Salman is still guided by the foreign policy decisions of the neighboring country, since the mentoring factor has played a key role. Perhaps it should be said that against the background of major failures and not the most successful internal and external initiatives, following and wanting to keep up with the United Arab Emirates is quite logical and one of the ways in which MBS strives to strengthen himself (after all, it was thanks to his mentor that he managed to achieve great success). Of course, this is not something unambiguous and is not openly stated, but it would be fair to note the existing connection and the "legacy" that led Saudi Arabia, led by Mohammed bin Salman, to strive to keep up with the UAE and look at their

foreign policy initiatives. The same applies to BRICS. Perhaps it was the UAE that served as an important driver for such a drastic step towards joining the association. Abu Dhabi has fully entered and become a member of the group, while Saudi Arabia is still considering the invitation it received, expressing its intention to join. It has already been mentioned about the significant advantages that Riyadh can get from full-fledged integration, especially with regard to the economy, but this is also true for the UAE, as a growing and developing economy in the Middle East. The unwillingness to concede to its rival for leadership in the region is also the reason for the Kingdom's actions to join BRICS.

Finally, it is worth analyzing the United States of America, an important strategic partner of the KSA. Saudi Arabia is the main buyer of weapons from the United States, and at the same time, Saudi Arabia is one of the key investment partners (America has already invested about 800 billion dollars in the Kingdom), which works towards greater interconnection between states. This research has previously evaluated the fact that relations between the two countries weakened and cooled during the Biden administration. This is very consistent with Saudi Arabia's efforts to reduce its strong unilateral dependence on its long-time ally by differentiating alliances and partnerships at the external level. However, it is worth noting that there is a strong and lasting connection with America, and the dependence has only decreased to a small extent. It is fair to say that the United States considers the Kingdom to be its key ally in the Middle East region, even more specifically in the Persian Gulf. For Washington, Saudi Arabia is an important partner through which it can advance its interests in the region and strengthen its global geopolitical position. Moreover, it is also important for America that the KSA is a serious player in terms of energy trade due to its extensive oil reserves, as well as natural gas. Having strategic and partnership relations with one of the dominant players in the oil and gas market is extremely important for Washington. All this is true in the context of the fact that the initiative on the part of the MBS to join BRICS is strongly linked, among other things, to the desire to benefit through pressure and “flirting” with the United

States. The BRICS bloc stands for multipolarity and a just world order, including seeking to challenge the global dominance of the West (in particular, Russia and China, but they project their goals and urges through this informal association). From this point of view, America cannot be seriously concerned about Mohammed bin Salman's intentions to fully join BRICS and strengthen integration with it. In addition, the reasoning of Dr. Fawaz Al-Alamy (2023) can be consider, the expert states that in the event of a possible escalation of the war in Ukraine into a World War, Saudi Arabia could use the so-called “eastern umbrella” in the event of a clash of interests between the West and the East (represented by Russia and China), this in this way, the country could more successfully meet the pressure of the West, which would undoubtedly be present. This indicates that BRICS can help the Kingdom cope with pressure and possible sanctions from the United States in case of a controversial or crisis situation in their relations. And although today the crisis in Ukraine does not portend an intensification and escalation of hostilities to a global level, BRICS can still serve as some kind of guarantor for the KSA, and in particular for MBS, to moderate balancing and create a “pressure lever” of pressure on the United States, which may be beneficial for the Kingdom. Indeed, against the background of Saudi Arabia's desire to join BRICS, America will probably want to establish closer partnerships with the Kingdom, thereby increasing the level of this partnership. In such a situation, MBS could greatly benefit from this in its future strategic steps – to take advantage of partnership with the United States on the one hand, and the advantages of China's rapidly growing influential economy on the other hand (from both the West and the East). Creating a “lever” of pressure on the United States is beneficial for obtaining profitable partnership agreements and strengthening this partnership with one of its main investors – the United States – because, as noted earlier, at the internal level of MBS's political activities, there is a strong need to finance his megaprojects, which in turn could play in favor of the Crown Prince himself. Saudi Arabia.

Thus, highlighting the key points at the external level, it is important to note the existing manner of following MBZ's foreign policy decisions, since previously

such a format allowed for successful decisions, as well as this approach is caused by the need to keep up with one of the key regional rivals (the desire to take advantage of, for example, joining BRICS, which in one way or another to a different extent, both the UAE and the KSA benefit). Moreover, joining BRICS would encourage the United States to strengthen its relations with Saudi Arabia, not wanting to miss it and give it more to its opponents, which of course would allow the Kingdom to benefit from its own ambitions and objectives. The external level is extremely important and necessary for MBS, as it is one of the few ways where the right political and geopolitical decisions will allow him to elevate himself both within his own state and in the international arena.

4.3 Why Has Saudi Arabia Not Fully Joined BRICS Yet?

Finally, at the end of this important chapter, it will be extremely crucial to analyze and try to answer the question why Saudi Arabia has not yet fully joined BRICS as it originally wanted. Here, of course, the figure of Mohammed bin Salman will be touched upon again in one way or another, which, as already mentioned, is one of the fundamental drivers (if not even the main one) in the movement towards BRICS. In this sub-chapter, it is mainly the external factors of pressure and deterrence on Saudi Arabia's path to the group that will be analyzed. The external level and foreign policy aspects largely determine the degree of initiative and speed of consideration of the invitation from the Kingdom. One of the most important reasons is probably the fact of the existing and remaining rivalry with Iran. As it is known, Tehran is already a full-fledged member of BRICS, and this clearly complicates the situation for Saudi Arabia. Of course, the countries restored diplomatic relations in 2023 with the mediation of China, but they still remain each other's main rivals for regional influence and dominance. Iran has recently been actively involved in proxy conflicts in the Middle East, and for some time now it has been supporting the Houthi group in Yemen (a long, protracted and not the most profitable war for Saudi Arabia). This group is a key opponent of Riyadh in this war, and the group also significantly complicates

navigation in the Red Sea, affecting the economic benefits of the KSA. Moreover, Iran is one of the key supporters of Hamas in the war against Israel, thereby acting as one of the main driving forces in the Middle East, trying to advance its influence and strengthen its position. This, in turn, complicates the implementation of The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), which is the most important project in the future for Saudi Arabia within the framework of Vision 2030. From this point of view, Israel and the United States can be mentioned, which are putting pressure on Riyadh not to join BRICS, where Iran is present. And Washington and Jerusalem need MBS to support them in promoting IMEC. And of course, since Riyadh is still not going to lose one of its key allies and suppliers of weapons to the United States (and, conversely, Washington is not interested in losing the KSA), which would provide significant security guarantees. In turn, Russia and China (one of the main and significant forces of BRICS) They are not ready to replace America in this role, which makes progress towards unification so slow.

First of all, it is worth considering perhaps one of the most important and key reasons why Saudi Arabia is still on its way to BRICS and has not fully integrated with the group. As already mentioned, this is Iran. And it's really fair to say this, because there are two ways globally: Iran itself is the main regional rival of the KSA, and also because of Iran's activity in the region in the framework of proxy conflicts and the war in Gaza, the United States and Israel are putting pressure on the Kingdom, in particular on the MBS, because these partners are important and necessary for Riyadh as part of the IMEC project. It is worth taking a closer look at the IMEC project itself. IMEC stands for The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor and is a major strategic initiative announced at the G20 summit in New Delhi in 2023. According to White House Archives (2023), this corridor is conceived as a large-scale multimodal infrastructure project that aims to connect India with Europe through the Middle East, in particular through Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Jordan and Israel. The essence of this corridor is an advanced infrastructure that consists of a network of railways, sea

routes, energy pipelines and digital infrastructure designed to improve the movement of goods, energy and data between key regions (Europe, the Middle East and Asia). In the FACT SHEET on the page White House Archives (2023), it is also noted that the United States emphasizes its “unwavering commitment” to make important regional economic investments, as well as the importance of creating and promoting this initiative together with partners. It turns out that Washington is going to act as one of the leading financial and investment forces within the framework of this initiative. As noted earlier in one of the previous sub-chapters, economic difficulties and lack of funding for major vital projects are taking place in the KSA, and this initiative is no exception. Saudi Arabia urgently needs a close partnership with the United States to implement this project, so American pressure is taking on a completely different degree and is hindering Riyadh's entry into BRICS.

And why is this project so important for the KSA? It can be discussed about the serious strategic and economic importance of this initiative for the country and, of course, for MBS, who strives for settlement and ambitious projects that should seriously strengthen the country and him as the future king. Firstly, IMEC positions and includes the Kingdom as the most important logistics hub between Asia, the Middle East and Europe (this so-called “route" connecting the continents). By doing this, Saudi Arabia can become and strive to become an important transit point for the flow of goods and energy resources. In turn, this approach contributes to Saudi Arabia's desire to diversify its economy, which is a key goal of the Vision 2030 plan. The Kingdom is committed to generating economic benefits from this initiative. Secondly, the IMEC project can also provide the KSA with an opportunity to strengthen political and economic ties with major global players. It is worth noting India, the European Union and the United States. These players are the most important forces and important partners for the Kingdom itself and MBS. Active participation in IMEC initiatives helps to strengthen the image of Riyadh as a key regional player and a modernizing force in the Middle East, and MBS as a successful reformer. Taking advantage of its

traditional alliance with the United States while strengthening relations with emerging Asian powers as well as Europe. Of course, we can note the fact that Saudi Arabia is striving to strengthen itself as a major player in the energy market. The corridor's construction plans include the transportation of clean energy, such as hydrogen, from the Middle East to Europe. This, in turn, could provide Riyadh with a new export market for its future green energy projects (which is also included in the Vision 2030 plan). It turns out that for Saudi Arabia, IMEC is not just a logistical project, but rather a great opportunity to gain a solid foundation for its broader ambitions for economic diversification, regional leadership, and strategic autonomy on the global stage.

Iran plays an important role here and is also indirectly involved in the "chain" of facts that prevent the Kingdom from implementing the IMEC project and the ambitious initiatives of MBS. Iran is acting as a regional rival for Riyadh even though diplomatic relations will be restored in 2023. Iran is one of the driving forces behind the Houthis in Yemen, with Saudi Arabia on the other side of the conflict. This proxy conflict has caused a lot of difficulties and problems for the Kingdom and is also an example of Mohammed bin Salman's less than successful foreign policy. Moreover, the Houthis are opposed to the United States and its presence in the region. They attack American ships, as Al Jazeera reported in January 2024, when a missile attack was carried out on ships. And US support for Israel in the war in the Gaza Strip also makes Washington a serious opponent for Tehran. Saudi Arabia relies on the rhetoric of the United States and its support in these conflicts. Moreover, the support of Israel and Washington is extremely important in the implementation of the IMEC project, which is vital for both the KSA and MBS. Conducting a dialogue with Israel (Iran's main opponent in the crisis in the Middle East) is necessary to promote the very existence of The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. And the war that Israel (and even the United States) is involved in is slowing down construction. In confirmation of the rhetoric against Iran by MBS, Ottoway (2021) writes in his book, where he notes that the Crown Prince positions himself as a regional bulwark against Iran

and Islamism, and also emphasizes that the creation of an anti-Iranian coalition is central to his foreign policy narrative. Of course, the book was written before the restoration of diplomatic relations and the path to normalization between the countries, but in connection with the above-mentioned foreign policy initiatives, the rhetoric against Iran is gaining momentum again. As for the place of BRICS in this issue, the anti-Iranian rhetoric from the United States and Israel (IMEC partners) has a serious impact and leads to pressure on Saudi Arabia, since Washington and Jerusalem probably do not want to see the KSA in the same union with Iran (which is BRICS). It is very important for Prince Mohammed bin Salman to have the investment power and support from the United States, including Israel, in order to implement and follow projects (such as Vision 2030 and IMEC). And the Kingdom's official membership in BRICS could undermine these important ties. Moreover, in confirmation of the strong rhetoric against Iran, one can cite the fact that after Trump's re-election as president of the United States, he introduced a policy of "maximum pressure" on Tehran, as reported by RT (2025). And besides, Trump does not treat BRICS in the best way, in particular because of their aspirations to create their own currency that could replace the American dollar. That is why sudden movements on the part of Saudi Arabia towards BRICS can lead to serious consequences – the United States may simply withdraw from the IMEC project or create conditions for pressure on Riyadh.

Additionally, it's worth noting very briefly that Saudi Arabia still relies heavily on weapons that the United States buys. America acts as the Kingdom's main defense partner, as well as a kind of guarantor of the security of the KSA. Major BRICS members such as Russia and China probably do not have much desire, and more importantly, the ability, to replace the United States for Saudi Arabia and become new guarantors. Therefore, this fact again works in Washington's favor, which can thereby exert influence and pressure, including on joining BRICS.

Summing up, the importance of the IMEC project for Saudi Arabia is extremely high, and it is expected that this particular initiative can bring more

tangible and significant benefits to the KSA than membership in BRICS. This, in turn, largely determines and provides an answer to why the Kingdom continues to delay joining the group. Israel and the United States can largely provide their geo-economic support, as well as financing for the IMEC project, and in this situation this can act as “levers” of pressure on Riyadh not to join BRICS. Moreover, these ways of pressure may not be so direct and obvious, but MBS and political representatives of Saudi Arabia are trying to sensibly assess the risks and severity of the consequences of joining BRICS. But it is important to note that nevertheless, the Kingdom does not reject full entry and deep integration with the union, because if an approach with proper maneuvering and balance is followed, the KSA can continue to take advantage of both its Western partnerships (including with Israel) and Eastern actors (BRICS, namely Russia, China and India).

4.4 Conclusion On the Chapter

As part of the general conclusion of this chapter, it is worth noting the existing logical relationship and interdependence between domestic and foreign policy factors that are behind the idea of joining BRICS and stopping the country from fully joining the group at the moment. The domestic political aspect lies in the unstable and difficult-to-predict environment that has been created by a serious political struggle on the part of Mohammed bin Salman in his quest to become Crown Prince instead MBN. This formed a certain attitude towards his figure on the part of the elite and the traditional establishment of the Kingdom. And his chosen path of serious reforms and ambitious projects is explained by an attempt to strengthen his own support by gaining support from modern society (mainly young people and women) in order to strengthen himself in the future as the future king of the country, earning “points" in his favor. However, the difficult financial and economic situation, especially with the financing of vital mega-projects, makes it extremely difficult to act exclusively at the internal level. Therefore, MBS is very much focused on the inside, as it can seek support there and gain so-called “points" there, including through participation in BRICS as a successful policy. As for

foreign policy factors as drivers towards BRICS, it is worth noting the existing pattern of following the policy of the neighboring UAE state under the leadership of MBZ, which had previously greatly helped MBS rise, and the first successful initiatives of the Saudi prince in foreign policy were made under the leadership and with the help of Mohammed bin Zayed. Moreover, we should not forget about the existing confrontation and rivalries between these states. And therefore, when Abu Dhabi successfully and fully joined BRICS, this most likely served as an excuse and a “wake-up call” for MBS to follow MBZ's example in order to keep up with its rival. As well as the orientation towards the foreign policy decisions of its neighbor, this step was also likely influenced. An important point at the external level is also an attempt to exert some pressure on the United States, a long-time ally and partner of the KSA, in order to strengthen partnerships and advantages on their part, since Saudi Arabia's entry into BRICS clearly does not follow Washington's goal of preserving its important partner, through which America is increasing its influence in the Middle East. Finally, as an answer to the question of Saudi Arabia's delayed accession to BRICS, we can conclude that the United States and Israel have significant influence on this issue, because Iran is present in the association – an opponent and rival of Jerusalem in the region, as well as a country that Washington exerts pressure on in every possible way. Both of these actors probably would not like to see Riyadh together with Tehran in the framework of BRICS. And the financial support from the United States and the Israeli contribution to the IMEC project are very important for Saudi Arabia to implement this very IMEC corridor as soon as possible, which is clearly in the interests of the IBS for the implementation of its projects and reforms (such as Vision 2030).

5. Conclusion

In conclusion, this research should summarize the results of the work carried out in the framework of studying the impact of Saudi Arabia's accession to BRICS on its foreign policy. Moreover, at this final stage, the answer to the research question posed will be considered and the hypothesis proposed at the beginning will be evaluated.

To begin with, this paper provides a comprehensive analysis of the potential implications of Saudi Arabia's entry into BRICS for its foreign policy. The aspects that motivate the country to join the association were described and studied, and as a result, these factors have a direct impact on the foreign policy of the KSA. As well as the opposite aspects, which to a large extent hinder and slow down entry, having negative or drastic changes in Riyadh's foreign policy.

The work began with the first important chapter, which examined and laid the theoretical foundation by examining the nature of international organizations and the unique characteristics of BRICS as a multilateral platform. Although this platform is not an international organization with a clear charter and system (as are the G7 and G20, by the way), it is still actively gaining momentum through its growth. This growing force cannot be ignored in the context of global dynamics and international relations in general. Rather, BRICS is a hybrid and informal association that promotes cooperation between the countries of the Global South and at the same time serves as a counterweight to the global governance structures led by the United States. It should be noted that BRICS functions not just as a coalition of emerging economies, but also as a symbol of an emerging alternative world order that challenges the dominance of traditional Western institutions. For Saudi Arabia, BRICS itself is presented as a new horizon of opportunities that would contribute to the country's internal and external aspirations. Therefore, it is not surprising that at one time the Kingdom expressed a desire to participate in the association as a full member, as a result of which it received an invitation there. However, at the time of writing this paper, Riyadh is still at the stage of

considering an invitation to BRICS and is not a full-fledged member. The situation itself is very interesting, especially in terms of the impact of joining and participating in BRICS on Saudi Arabia's foreign policy, which is why this study was conducted.

Due attention was paid to the immediate facts that, to one degree or another, motivate the KSA to fully join BRICS and, as a result, receive these very benefits. A focused study of Saudi Arabia's motives for entering into BRICS structure and the practical benefits it expects has formed an important understanding of why the country still wants to integrate and not lose touch with the association. These factors are directly related to the Kingdom's foreign policy ambitions, which consist in the devertification of its alliances and partnerships on the global stage by carefully balancing between the West (the traditional ally of the United States) and the East, as well as its own national geopolitical interests, which the country and its leadership as a whole pursue. BRICS can become an important strategic platform for advanced foreign policy on the part of the KSA, as this platform can provide extensive and flexible opportunities for the formation and conclusion of multilateral partnerships with member countries, which can certainly influence the course of Riyadh's foreign policy. And, of course, serious and sometimes critical issues that could hinder Saudi Arabia's full integration with BRICS were considered. If we note from the point of view of the external level, that is, the foreign policy on the part of Riyadh, then it is worth saying that the path of balancing is not as simple and obvious as it seems. The Kingdom is not interested (and to some extent cannot even completely) get rid of its major Western partner, the United States. There is a significant unilateral dependence that has been formed through large-scale investments from Washington (and vice versa), as well as the need for further financing of large and vital projects for Saudi Arabia, such as initiatives within the framework of Vision 2030 and, of course, such significant foreign policy projects as IMEC, which is directly related to the country's growth on the global stage. It also has an impact on relations with key forces in the Middle East region (such as Israel and Iran). Moreover, strong and lasting cooperation with

the United States has been noted in the field of defense and security, perhaps one of the key points on which Saudi Arabia wants to continue cooperation, has its significant pressure on the Kingdom within the framework of its foreign policy.

Finally, in addition, two key levels in the KSA were considered, which largely determine the movement towards BRICS – the internal and external levels. At both levels, the influential figure of Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman is in many ways the driving force behind both the country's domestic and foreign policy. The search for legitimacy and strengthening of his own figure within the Kingdom as a likely future king led MBS to large-scale internal reforms, which caused contradictory sentiments in the country. His very rise to power created a tense environment inside, which, among other things, forced MBS to focus his attention as much as possible on the external level – the level of Saudi Arabia's foreign policy. The Kingdom's application to join BRICS and the movement towards unification itself can be interpreted not only as a geopolitical maneuver, but also as a strategic tool to strengthen the international authority of the Crown Prince and his political capital in the face of internal economic tensions and elite confrontation. All of this has a direct impact on the foreign policy of the entire Kingdom, including in the framework of considering the country in the BRICS structure. The comparison with the UAE's more assertive and independent foreign policy with its president largely underscores the importance of BRICS as a diplomatic counterweight and a means of regional influence that both countries are fighting for.

Answering the research question posed and at the same time evaluating the established hypothesis, it should be said that Saudi Arabia's accession to BRICS can significantly affect the course of its foreign policy, as well as directly affect its relations with key forces in the Middle East region. A number of countries affected in this study – the UAE, Iran and Israel - are behind these forces. From the UAE's point of view, it is important to note the nature of the competition for influence in the region, as well as the growth of strong sovereign states. Abu Dhabi is already a full-fledged BRICS member, which allows it to have some advantage over its rival,

and Saudi Arabia's full participation there will probably even their chances, entrenching rivalry and forcing both countries to seek to extract as much benefit as possible through an agenda of unification and group initiatives. The situation with Israel is quite clear – it does not accept Saudi Arabia's presence in BRICS, since Iran is present there. Iran is a key rival and opponent of Jerusalem, and the United States, against the background of its allied ties with Israel and Trump's policies, is clearly in a similar position. The KSA's entry into the association is not explicitly encouraged by Israel and Washington, which are very important and key partners on which the implementation of the IMEC project (one of the key ones for Riyadh's foreign policy success and growth) depends. In many ways, these two countries (the United States and Israel) act as factors and reasons why Saudi Arabia is still hesitating to join BRICS. Both of these states do not accept the Kingdom's presence within the framework of the association, since Iran is present there. Financial support and heavy dependence from the point of view of mutual investments with the United States complicate and slow down the process of Saudi Arabia's accession. Israel in turn is an important ally and partner of Washington, and the success and speed of the IMEC project within the Middle East region largely depends on Jerusalem.

It is also safe to say that the hypothesis posed at the beginning of the work has been proven. After all, Saudi Arabia's entry into BRICS will clearly lead to a significant reorientation of its foreign policy. This will be reflected in the strategic diversification of alliances beyond the traditional Western axis by balancing and establishing new contacts with the BRICS countries. Moreover, the Kingdom's accession will manifest itself in the expansion of economic and political cooperation with the member countries of the association through multilateral contracts and participation in group initiatives that can benefit Riyadh. Moreover, the accession itself will significantly affect the redistribution of regional influence in the Middle East, which will be reflected in mutual relations with regional actors (such as the UAE, Israel and Iran). And Saudi Arabia's participation in BRICS will also lead to a gradual reconfiguration in the field of security and financial

dependencies, while balancing existing partnerships, especially with the United States.

Taken together, the results of this study indicate that Saudi Arabia's integration into BRICS is both a reflection and a catalyst for a change in its foreign policy identity and vector in general. This indicates a departure from the Kingdom's historically Western-oriented diplomacy towards a more autonomous, multidirectional and pragmatic approach to international affairs. Although full-fledged membership in BRICS has not yet taken place, the Kingdom's active interaction with the association already indicates a desire not to lose this opportunity.

6. Reference List / Bibliography

Abdelaziz Abdeldayem, F.M. and Wadie Kswat, S.F. (2024). "BRICS expansion in the news coverage of member countries: a political economy perspective", Journal of Humanities and Applied Social Sciences, Vol. ahead-of-print No. ahead-of-print.

AIM Congress. (n.d.). Annual Investment Meeting 2024. Retrieved from https://aimcongress.com/

Aleksandra Rabczun (2024). Perspective of Arabian Members of BRICS—New Possibilities Thanks to Expansion

Alhasan, H., Hammad, N., & Alajlouni, L. (2023). With the expansion of BRICS, China and Middle Eastern powers are drawing closer.

Al Jazeera. (2021, February 26). MBS approved operation to capture or kill Khashoggi: US report. Al Jazeera. Retrieved from https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/2/26/mbs-oversaw-saudi-killers-of-khashoggi-us-intel-report

Al Jazeera. (2022, December 6). China's Xi arrives in Saudi Arabia to 'bolster ties'. Al Jazeera. Retrieved from https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/12/6/chinas-xi-to-visit-saudi-arabia-from-wednesday

Al Jazeera. (2024, January 15). Yemen's Houthis hit US-owned ship in missile attack, US military says. Retrieved from https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/1/15/yemens-houthis-hit-us-owned-ship-in-missile-attack-us-military-says

Anghel, V., & Jones, E. (2024). The enlargement of international organisations. West European Politics, 48(1), 1–28. https://doi.org/10.1080/01402382.2024.2311044

Antonios Valamontes Editor John Karantonis (2024). The Upcoming BRICS Summit: Saudi Arabia's Potential Membership and Global Economic Implications.

Arab News. (2018, June 10). FaceOf: Turki Al-Alshaikh, Saudi General Sports Authority chairman. Retrieved from https://www.arabnews.com/node/1319266/saudi-arabia

Arab News. (2024, October 24). Saudi foreign minister commits to BRICS cooperation at Kazan summit. Arab News. Retrieved from https://www.arabnews.com/node/2576648/saudi-arabia

Artner, A., & Yin, Z. (2023). Towards a non-hegemonic world order – emancipation and the political agency of the Global South in a changing world order. Third World Quarterly, 44(10), 2193–2207. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2023.2251422

Asia Times. (2025, February 5). Trump gives Saudi Arabia cause to pause joining BRICS. Asia Times. Retrieved from https://asiatimes.com/2025/02/trump-gives-saudi-arabia-cause-to-pause-joining-brics/

Barbary, M.M. (2024). The Impact of Saudi Arabia's Accession to the Brics Bloc on the Performance of Saudi Exports. ECONOMICS, 2023, Sciendo, vol. 0 no. 0

Barkin, J. S. (2023). International Organization. Theories and Institutions. Third Edition. New York.

Bavier, J. (2023). BRICS expansion hopefuls seek to rebalance world order.

BBC News. (2017, October 25). Crown prince says Saudis want return to moderate Islam. Retrieved from https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-41747476

Belt and Road Portal. (2024, January 10). BRICS countries strengthen cooperation through close economic and trade exchanges. Belt and Road Portal. Retrieved from https://eng.yidaiyilu.gov.cn/p/06VN7335.html

Bloomberg. (2016, April 21). The $2 Trillion Project to Get Saudi Arabia's Economy Off Oil. Bloomberg. Retrieved from https://www.bloomberg.com/news/features/2016-04-21/the-2-trillion-project-to-get-saudi-arabia-s-economy-off-oil

Bloomberg. (2023, January 17). Saudi Arabia Says Open to Settling Trade in Other Currencies. Bloomberg. Retrieved from https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2023-01-17/saudi-arabia-open-to-talks-on-trade-in-currencies-besides-dollar

Bloomberg. (2023, May 10). South Africa urges careful debate on option of introducing BRICS common currency. Bloomberg. Retrieved from https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2023-05-10/south-africa-urges-careful-debate-on-option-of-introducing-brics-common-currency

Bloomberg. (2025, January 7). Saudi Arabia Starts 2025 With a $12 Billion Bond and PIF Loan. Retrieved from https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2025-01-06/saudi-arabia-plans-37-billion-borrowing-spree-to-pay-for-huge-projects

Borshchevskaya, A. (2024). How the Middle East Became an Arena for Putin's Power Struggle with the US.

Boston Consulting Group. (2024, March). An Evolving BRICS and the Shifting World Order. Retrieved from https://www.bcg.com/publications/2024/brics-enlargement-and-shifting-world-order?utm_source=chatgpt.com

BRICS. (n.d.). History of BRICS. Retrieved from - https://infobrics.org/page/history-of-brics/

BRICS 2023. (n.d.). Evolution of BRICS. Retrieved from https://brics2023.gov.za/evolution-of-brics/

BRICS Russia. (2024). Yuriy Ushakov: BRICS na dele vyrazhaet interesy mirovogo bolshinstva. "Yuri Ushakov: BRICS actually expresses the interests of the global majority". Retrieved from https://brics-russia2024.ru/interview/yuriy-ushakov-briks-na-dele-vyrazhaet-interesy-mirovogo-bolshinstva/?sphrase_id=42052

BRICS Trade Ministers. (2024, July 10). Joint Communiqué of the 14th BRICS Trade Ministers Meeting. Retrieved from

https://cdn.brics-russia2024.ru/upload/docs/JOINT_COMMUNIQUE_OF_THE_14TH_BRICS_TRADE_MINISTERS_MEETING.pdf?1724688970432977

Buenos Aires Times. (2023, August 24). Argentina's BRICS membership in doubt as opposition rejects move. Buenos Aires Times. Retrieved from https://www.batimes.com.ar/news/argentina/argentinas-brics-membership-in-doubt-as-opposition-rejects-move.phtml

Butt, J. S. (2024). From Dollar Dependency to BRICS Autonomy: Legal and Economic Impacts on Global Trade Governance. Acta Universitatis Danubius. Œconomica, 20(6).

Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. (2024, October). BRICS Expansion, the G20, and the Future of World Order. Retrieved from https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2024/10/brics-summit-emerging-middle-powers-g7-g20?utm_source=chatgpt.com&lang=en

Castro, A. (2013). The BRICS as a Coalition: Analysing the Cooperation of Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa in the International Monetary Fund and the G-20.

Channel News Asia. (2024, October 24). Malaysia, Indonesia, Vietnam and Thailand become partner countries of BRICS. Channel News Asia. Retrieved from https://www.channelnewsasia.com/asia/malaysia-indonesia-vietnam-thailand-brics-asean-global-south-russia-china-4699841

CNBC. (2020, September 23). President Xi tells UN that China will be 'carbon neutral' within four decades. CNBC. Retrieved from https://www.cnbc.com/2020/09/23/china-claims-it-will-be-carbon-neutral-by-the-year-2060.html

CNN. (2020, March 8). Oil crashes by most since 1991 as Saudi Arabia launches price war. CNN Business. Retrieved from https://edition.cnn.com/2020/03/08/investing/oil-prices-crash-opec-russia-saudi-arabia/index.html

Curtis, J. (2024). The BRICS group: Overview and recent expansion (Research Briefing No. 10136). House of Commons Library. Retrieved from https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/sn03207/

da Costa, S. J. A., & Sattler, T. (2020). Are we going towards a Multipolar World Order? An analysis of BRICS and Regional Organizations.

Davidson, C. M. (n.d.). MOHAMMED BIN SALMAN AL SAUD (AKA "MBS"). *Dictators and Autocrats*, 319.

Debre, M., & Dijkstra, H. (2023). Are international organisations in decline? An absolute and relative perspective on institutional change. Global Policy, 14(1), 16-30. https://doi.org/10.1111/1758-5899.13170

Dr. Abdulaziz Sager (2024). Kingdom of Saudi Arabia:Emerging Middle Power in Global Dynamics

El Cronista. (2023, November 30). Diana Mondino confirmó que la Argentina no ingresará a los BRICS. El Cronista. Retrieved from https://www.cronista.com/economia-politica/diana-mondino-confirmo-que-la-argentina-no-ingresara-a-los-brics/

Energy Intelligence. (2023). Q&A: Saudi Energy Minister Highlights Oil Market Risks. Retrieved from https://www.energyintel.com/00000186-e11b-d0fe-a7ae-e51ffa6a0000

European Foundation for South Asian Studies. (2023). The BRICS | Origins, Evolution & 2023 Expansion. Retrieved from https://www.efsas.org/publications/study-papers/the-brics-origins-evolution-and-expansion/

European Foundation for South Asian Studies (EFSAS) (2023). The BRICS | Origins, Evolution & 2023 Expansion.

Folha de S.Paulo. (2024, October 23). Brazil Blocks Caracas' Bid to Join BRICS as a New Partner Country. Retrieved from https://www1.folha.uol.com.br/internacional/en/world/2024/10/brazil-blocks-caracas-bid-to-join-brics-as-a-new-partner-country.shtml

Forbes. (2017, May 20). Blackstone Unveils $40 Billion Infrastructure Mega Fund With Saudi Arabia As Trump Visits. Forbes. Retrieved from https://www.forbes.com/sites/antoinegara/2017/05/20/blackstone-unveils-40-billion-infrastructure-mega-fund-with-saudi-arabia-as-trump-visits/#3d44b92267ad

Foreign Policy. (2023, November 2). Why the Global South Is Accusing America of Hypocrisy. Foreign Policy. Retrieved from https://foreignpolicy.com/2023/11/02/israel-palestine-hamas-gaza-war-russia-ukraine-occupation-west-hypocrisy/

Gavrilenko, V., & Shenshin, V. (2024). BRICS Expansion: A Geopolitical Triumph of Partner Countries. BRICS Law Journal, 11(3), 9-53.

Gjevori, E. (2023). How Brics is looking to challenge the Western order in the Middle East.

Government of Saudi Arabia. (n.d.). Saudi Vision 2030. Retrieved from https://www.vision2030.gov.sa/en

Haas, E. B. (2024). Beyond the nation-state: Functionalism and international organization. ECPR Press.

Hana Al-Khamri. (2020, March 10). MBS and the Saudi crisis of legitimacy. Al Jazeera. Retrieved from https://www.aljazeera.com/opinions/2020/3/10/mbs-and-the-saudi-crisis-of-legitimacy

Holtzmann, D. H.-D. (2024). BRICS enlargement - a “non-event” or a stage victory against the West?

Hope, B., & Scheck, J. (2020). Blood and Oil: Mohammed bin Salman's Ruthless Quest for Global Power. Hachette UK.

Huntington, S. P. (1968). Political order in changing societies (pp. 177–189). Yale University Press.

InfoBRICS. (2025, February 18). *BRICS membership offers global South investment alternatives*. InfoBRICS. Retrieved from https://infobrics.org/post/43473

International Monetary Fund. (n.d.). Currency Composition of Official Foreign Exchange Reserves (COFER) [Dataset]. IMF Data. Retrieved from https://data.imf.org/en/Data-Explorer?datasetUrn=IMF.STA:COFER(7.0.0)

Jr, R. P. B. (2024). Can the expanded BRICS pave a new path in global development?

Kamin, K., & Langhammer, R. J. (2024). BRICS+: a Wake-Up Call for the G7?. Cuadernos Económicos de ICE, (107), 133-145.

Kamin, K., & Langhammer, R. J. (2024). From BRICS to BRICS+: Sheer More Members is not a Challenge to G7. The Economists' Voice, 20(2), 259-265.

Katz, M. N. (2023). The BRICS Come to the Middle East and North Africa

Katz, M. N. (2024). The Geopolitical (In) Significance of BRICS Enlargement

Keohane, R. O. (1984). After hegemony: Cooperation and discord in the world political economy. Princeton University Press.

Konyshev, V., & Sergunin, A. (2022). Theoretical Perspectives on BRICS: What Kind of an International Institution Is It?. In Turning Points of World Transformation: New Trends, Challenges and Actors (pp. 101-115). Singapore: Springer Nature Singapore.

Kremlin. (2009, June 16). First BRIC summit took place in Yekaterinburg. Retrieved from http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/4478

Kremlin. (2024, October 24). News conference following 16th BRICS Summit. Retrieved from http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/75385

Lee, B. T. F., & Sims, J. P. (2024). The BRICS+ Expansion, Global Trade Dynamics, and the Dedollarization Phenomenon. Unnes Political Science Journal, 8(1), 19-29.

Lissovolik Yaroslav (2024). BRICS expansion: new geographies and spheres of cooperation

Logan Cochrane & Esmat Zaidan (2024). Shifting global dynamics: an empirical analysis of BRICS + expansion and its economic, trade, and military

implications in the context of the G7, Cogent Social Sciences, 10:1, 2333422, DOI: 10.1080/23311886.2024.2333422

Maaal. (2023, June 5). "إيجابيات وسلبيات الانضمام لمجموعة "بريكس. "Pros and cons of joining the "BRICS"group". Maaal. Retrieved from https://maaal.com/2023/06/إيجابيات-وسلبيات-الانضمام-لمجموعة-بر/

Malik, I. Y., Kohar, H. Y., & Tungkagi, H. N. Z. (2024). BRICS expansion in the Middle East from political economy perspective. Center of Middle Eastern Studies (CMES), 17(1), 77-88.

Mearsheimer, J. J. (1994). The false promise of international institutions. International Security, 19(3), 5–49. https://doi.org/10.2307/2539078

Melvin, D. N. (2023). Building Up the BRICS: An Emerging Counter-West Order?

Middle East Briefing. (2023, September 12). Saudi Arabia and BRICS: The Consequences of Joining, Multilateral Trade and Prospects. Middle East Briefing. Retrieved from https://www.middleeastbriefing.com/news/saudi-arabia-and-brics-the-consequences-of-joining-multilateral-trade-and-prospects/

Middle East Monitor. (2020, November 4). Saudi takes out loan to fund mega-city projects. Retrieved from https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20201104-saudi-takes-out-loan-to-fund-mega-city-projects/

Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Saudi Arabia. (2024). نيابةً عن خادم الحرمين الشريفين.. سمو وزير الخارجية يرأس وفد المملكة المشارك في قمة بريكس بلس 2024. "On behalf of the custodian of the Two Holy Mosques.. His Highness The Minister of Foreign Affairs heads the kingdom's delegation participating in the BRICS Plus summit 2024". Retrieved from https://www.mofa.gov.sa/ar/ministry/statements/Pages/F557.aspx

Ministry of New and Renewable Energy. (2025). National Green Hydrogen Mission. Retrieved from https://mnre.gov.in/en/hydrogen-overview/

Nam, C. W. (2024). Introduction to the issue on BRICS enlargement: What are the geoeconomic implications?. In EconPol Forum (Vol. 25, No. 1, pp. 3-4). Munich: CESifo GmbH.

NDTV. (2025, February 28). As Trump Boasts "BRICS Is Dead", New De-Dollarisation Call Comes As A Jolt. Retrieved from https://www.ndtv.com/world-news/as-donald-trump-boasts-brics-is-dead-new-de-dollarisation-call-comes-as-a-jolt-7817740

Neill, J. O. (2002). Building Better Global Economic BRICs. Global Economics Paper, (November 2001).

New Development Bank. (2022). Agreement on the New Development Bank. Retrieved from https://www.ndb.int/wp-content/uploads/2022/11/Agreement-on-the-New-Development-Bank.pdf

New Development Bank. (n.d.). About NDB. Retrieved from https://www.ndb.int/about-ndb/

Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries. (2024). Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, Kazakhstan, Algeria, and Oman extend voluntary cuts. Retrieved from https://www.opec.org/pr-detail/17-05-sep-2024.html

Ottaway, D. (2021). *Mohammed Bin Salman: The Icarus of Saudi Arabia?*. Lynne Rienner Publishers, Incorporated.

Pádraig Carmody (2024). BRICS' Enlargement: Power Expansion or Contraction in a Changing World Order?

Papa, M., & Han, Z. (2025). The evolution of soft balancing in informal institutions: the case of BRICS. International Affairs, 101(1), 73-95.

Peters, M. A. (2022). The emerging multipolar world order: A preliminary analysis. Educational Philosophy and Theory, 55(14), 1653–1663. https://doi.org/10.1080/00131857.2022.2151896

Press Information Bureau.Government of India. (2023, May 4). Raksha Mantri meets China's State Councillor & Minister of National Defence ahead of

SCO Defence Ministers' meeting in New Delhi. Government of India. Retrieved from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1920322

Reuters. (2017, November 6). Future Saudi king tightens grip on power with arrests including Prince Alwaleed. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/article/us-saudi-arrests/future-saudi-king-tightens-grip-on-power-with-arrests-including-prince-alwaleed-idUSKBN1D506P/

Reuters. (2019, July 18). U.S. House rejects Saudi weapons sales; Trump to veto. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-saudi-arms/house-rejects-saudi-weapons-sales-trump-to-veto-idUSKCN1UC2US/

Reuters. (2022, March 13). Sanctions have frozen around $300 bln of Russian reserves, FinMin says. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/article/ukraine-crisis-russia-reserves-idUSL5N2VG0BU/

Reuters. (2023, December 7). Russia's Putin told Saudi's MbS: We meet in Moscow next time. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/world/russias-putin-told-saudis-mbs-we-meet-moscow-next-time-2023-12-07/

Reuters. (2024, February 2). Saudi Arabia pushes for U.S. defense pact ahead of presidential election. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/saudi-arabia-pushes-us-defence-pact-ahead-presidential-election-2024-02-02/

Reuters. (2024, January 16). Saudi Arabia has not yet joined BRICs - minister. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/world/saudi-arabia-has-not-yet-joined-brics-minister-2024-01-16/

Reuters. (2024). Saudi Arabia has not yet joined BRICS - Saudi official source.

Reuters. (2025, February 13). Brazil nixes BRICS currency, eyes less reliance on 'mighty' dollar. Reuters. Retrieved from

https://www.reuters.com/markets/currencies/brazil-nixes-brics-currency-eyes-less-reliance-mighty-dollar-2025-02-13/

Reuters. (2025, February 13). Trump warns BRICS nations could face 100% tariffs. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/world/trump-warns-brics-nations-could-face-100-tariffs-2025-02-13/

Reuters. (2025, January 23). Saudi Arabia plans $600 billion in new US investment, trade over four years. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/saudi-crown-prince-seeks-600-bln-investment-push-with-us-2025-01-22/

Reuters. (2025, March 31). Percent of global FX reserves in dollars ticks up; amounts fall – IMF data shows. Reuters. Retrieved from https://www.reuters.com/markets/currencies/percent-global-fx-reserves-dollars-ticks-up-amounts-fall-imf-data-shows-2025-03-31/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

RIA Novosti. (2025, January 31). V BRICS ne obsyzhdayut sozdanie obshchey valyuty — Peskov. "BRICS are not discussing the creation of a common currency, Peskov said". RIA Novosti. Retrieved from https://ria.ru/20250131/peskov-1996596307.html

RT News. (2025, February 12). Trump's Ukraine envoy calls for 'maximum pressure' on Tehran. Retrieved from https://www.rt.com/news/610763-trump-envoy-iran-pressure/

Sato, T. (2023). Evolving constitutions of international organizations: a critical analysis of the interpretative framework of the constituent instruments of international organizations (Vol. 3). Martinus Nijhoff Publishers.

Stockholm International Peace Research Institute. (2025). SIPRI Military Expenditure Database. Retrieved from https://milex.sipri.org/sipri

TASS. (2023, August 29). Ethiopia's accession to BRICS facilitates creation of fair global system — diplomat. TASS. Retrieved from https://tass.com/world/1666913

TASS. (2024, March 5). Interv'yu s predstavitelem Rossii v BRICS. “Interview with the representative of Russia in BRICS”. TASS. Retrieved from https://tass.ru/interviews/20149675

The Guardian. (2018, November 23). ‘Hedges case may signal UAE kickback against western criticism’.

The Guardian. (2020, August 31). India accuses China of 'provocative military movements' near border. The Guardian. Retrieved from https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/aug/31/india-accuses-china-of-provocative-military-movements-near-border

The Independent. (2023, August 24). Brics countries agree historic expansion as six new countries invited to join. Retrieved from https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/africa/brics-2023-summit-new-members-saudi-uae-iran-b2398553.html

The New York Times. (2019, September 14). Two Major Saudi Oil Installations Hit by Drone Strike, and U.S. Blames Iran. The New York Times. Retrieved from https://www.nytimes.com/2019/09/14/world/middleeast/saudi-arabia-refineries-drone-attack.html

The New York Times. (2020, January 9). 'Mohammed bin Zayed’s Dark Vision of the Middle East’s Future'.

The Wall Street Journal. (2025, March 9). What Went Wrong at Saudi Arabia’s Futuristic Metropolis in the Desert. The Wall Street Journal. Retrieved from https://www.wsj.com/finance/saudi-arabia-neom-sindalah-15b9f25a

The White House. (2023, September 9). FACT SHEET: World Leaders Launch a Landmark India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. Retrieved from https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2023/09/09/fact-sheet-world-leaders-launch-a-landmark-india-middle-east-europe-economic-corridor/

Trump, D. (2025, January 31). [The idea that the BRICS Countries are trying to move away from the Dollar, while we stand by and watch, is OVER. We are going to require a commitment from these seemingly hostile Countries that

they will neither create a new BRICS Currency, nor back any other Currency to replace the mighty U.S. Dollar or, they will face 100% Tariffs, and should expect to say goodbye to selling into the wonderful U.S. Economy. They can go find another sucker Nation. There is no chance that BRICS will replace the U.S. Dollar in International Trade, or anywhere else, and any Country that tries should say hello to Tariffs, and goodbye to America!] [Post]. Truth Social. Retrieved from https://truthsocial.com/@realDonaldTrump/posts/113920366067218393

Trump, D. [@realDonaldTrump]. (2024, Decemberl 1). [The idea that the BRICS Countries are trying to move away from the Dollar while we stand by and watch is OVER. We require a commitment from these Countries that they will neither create a new BRICS Currency, nor back any other Currency to replace the mighty U.S. Dollar or, they will face 100% Tariffs, and should expect to say goodbye to selling into the wonderful U.S. Economy. They can go find another "sucker!" There is no chance that the BRICS will replace the U.S. Dollar in International Trade, and any Country that tries should wave goodbye to America.] [Tweet]. X. Retrieved from https://x.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1863009545858998512

TV BRICS. (2023, August 24). Yuar i Saudovskaya Araviya Uvelichat Obemy Dvustoronney Torgovli i Investitsiy. "South Africa and Saudi Arabia to increase bilateral trade and investment". TV BRICS. Retrieved from https://tvbrics.com/news/yuar-i-saudovskaya-araviya-uvelichat-obemy-dvustoronney-torgovli-i-investitsiy/

TV BRICS. (2024, May 13). Annual Investment Congress in UAE discusses impact of BRICS countries on global economy. TV BRICS. Retrieved from https://tvbrics.com/en/news/annual-investment-congress-in-uae-discusses-impact-of-brics-countries-on-global-economy/?sphrase_id=10899

TV BRICS. (2024, November 29). Investment opportunities of the BRICS countries. TV BRICS. Retrieved from https://tvbrics.com/en/news/investment-opportunities-of-the-brics-countries/

U.S. Department of State. (1933). Memorandum of Conversation: Ibn Saud and U.S. Interests. In Foreign Relations of the United States, 1933, Volume II. Retrieved from https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1933v02/d756

U.S. Department of State. (2025, January 20). U.S. Security Cooperation With Saudi Arabia. Retrieved from https://www.state.gov/u-s-security-cooperation-with-saudi-arabia/

UBS. (2024, December 2). Why the US-dollar-centric world is likely to continue for years to come. UBS. Retrieved from https://www.ubs.com/global/en/wealthmanagement/insights/marketnews/article.1703431.html

Ullah, I., Haider, S. M., & Gohar, M. (2024). BRICS Expansion: Prospects and Challenges. Research Journal of Human and Social Aspects, 2(1), 52-64.

US Department of State. (2005, October 15). 'MBZ meeting with senior advisor on Iraq Jeffrey (cable: 05ABUDHABI4308_a)'.

US Department of State. (2009, October 15). 'A long hot summer for UAE-Saudi relations (cable: 09ABUDHABI981_a)'.

Vasileski, Z. (n.d.). BRICS VERSUS THE GLOBAL WEST IN THE LIGHT OF CURRENT GLOBAL REALIZATIONS. Towards a Better Future: Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions, 291.